

DROPZONE

COMMANDER



RECONQUEST PRIMER 2

OFFICER OF THE COLONIAL MILITARY

Enclosed is a report detailing the current state of the war in brief as of this, the 500th day since hostilities against the Scourge were opened on Eden Prime. This report may have been redacted to match your security clearance level. Any attempt to disseminate the contents of this report to lower clearance levels will be met with summary court martial. Leaks above level 4 will be treated as high treason and dealt with accordingly.

The report contains sections covering each major theatre of operations. As for all officers, it is vitally important that you keep yourself informed as to the progress of the wider war beyond the specific theatre in which you are deployed. The decisions of your superiors will be vindicated in light of the bigger picture, the greatest war mankind has ever known. If you are temporarily denied troops or resupply, you must accept and understand this, given the wider context of the war. Your part in this endeavour is vital to the very future of our species and only discipline, courage and rigorous application of your training and will see us to victory.

The Colonies thank you for your service. For Mankind, For the Colonies, For Vengeance.

Supreme Martial Yuri T. Zachiev, UCMA



EDEN SYSTEM

OCT 19TH, 2671AD, D+500



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

OVERVIEW

SURFACE OPERATIONS - EDEN PRIME

Although the Reconquest Plan as a whole is now in Phase 2, the situation on Eden Prime can be considered to have entered Phase 3. Virtually the entire surface of Eden Prime is now under UCM control with only a few serious enemy concentrations remaining. At this time we have the bulk of the remaining Scourge strength either boxed into the inner precincts of the Southern city of Star Casablanca or contained in the far northern city of New Athens.

Reconstruction and repurposing of the captured assets in New Troy and Romagrad is well underway and Eden Prime should be in a position to positively contribute to the war effort shortly. The UCMA has also begun recruiting for the first Legion to be raised from a recaptured Cradle World, a fighting formation projected to be one of the most elite in the entire military from the moment of its formation due to the toughness and combat experience of its ex-Resistance recruits.

Total victory was projected to have been achieved on the entire planet well over 100 days ago at worst estimates, but unfortunately we have faced a tragic setback. Conquest looked to be all but achieved by the end of June and AHQ deemed the time was right to begin mass lifts of troops from the surface to bolster the Elysian and Shangri-La campaigns as planned.

Shortly after 70% of our strength was removed from theatre, the final assault of Atlantia City began. This frozen and blighted city had been a thorn in our side since the early days of the campaign as the Scourge seemed to have chosen it as a place to make a stand. This was further complicated by the presence of the despotic and feral warlord Salakahn, aided and goaded by agents of the PHR.

The assault was spearheaded by the entire Maganum Second Legion at 80% strength (800,000 men) and two full strength Armoured Corps fresh from Ferrum (200,000 men + vehicle support). The attack was going well through the first few days, as our forces pushed into an ever increasing salient directed at the city centre - the heart of both Scourge and Feral leadership. Our advances in certain sectors was hindered or repulsed by surgical PHR attacks however, which delayed the general offensive by well over 48 hours. Unfortunately, this proved grievously costly.

Intelligence suggests that the PHR forces in league with Salakahn had a mysterious purpose of their own to achieve in the city before we achieved total victory. The alliance between the PHR and the Ferals always seemed unlikely and mismatched, although our spies within Salakahn's court seemed to intimate that the PHR were pulling his strings. Unfortunately, it seems that the ruthless despot had plans of his own. As our forces entered the city centre on the seventh day (June 30th), his twisted plan was unleashed.

As Fleet Command lost all comms with our surface assets in Atlantia, a blinding flash was witnessed from the viewports of our orbiting ships. Seconds later, radiological alarms signalled that something cataclysmic had happened on the surface. The horrifying truth quickly became obvious, as the tortured screams and panic of our outer garrisons blared over the net. Salakahn's forces had detonated a score of subsurface nuclear warheads, virtually levelling the entire city, turning the centre to molten glass and taking almost a million loyal colonial lives in the blink of an eye. Such a monstrous crime will enter the annals of the worst evils our race has inflicted on itself and marks the first use of strategic nuclear weapons in this conflict, not to mention the most casualties we have ever sustained in a single day, over double that of D-Day itself.

It would be a pathetic compensation to learn that Salakahn died along with his plan, but we must doubt that such a selfish survivalist would ever sacrifice his own life. We must assume that he quit the city along with the majority of his lackeys before the atrocity. Indeed, Honorary General Karl Foley was in pursuit of a large column of Ferals fleeing the

outskirts at the time of the attack. Although his compassion in turning back to the city to aid in the recovery effort should be commended, it may have allowed the tyrant's escape.

The total annihilation of what must amount to millions of Scourge cannot compensate the United Colonies for the losses sustained on that fateful day. Small comfort that the PHR were dealt payback for being in league with such a snake, as their own forces were reduced to ash alongside ours.

Whether they achieved their nefarious purpose before their ignoble demise is unknown at this time.

PERSONAL FOOTNOTE:

I apologise for the increasingly emotive language I have used in this section sirs. One should write these reports in the official, detached format but in this case I must fail to do so, as I lost a brave son and daughter to this, the worst atrocity of the war. Yours in grief, Tobias Moran, Senate Records Officer 1st class.

NOTE APPENDED BY REPORT EDITOR JUAN JACOBS:

I chose to make an exception to standards and leave this section in the report intact; such voices highlight the real human cost of this war on a personal level which should not be ignored. RO Moran was relieved of his duty after submission of this, the first section of the D+500 report for convalescence and mourning on Maganum, since he became unable to continue writing. The Senate acknowledges his fine service and hopes to welcome him back soon.

I have enclosed the last eyewitness account we have from our spy (now presumed KIA) in Salakahn's court before the attack. (Side note: The Naval Theory department failed to read between the lines of this account before it was too late, and have been taken to task for this oversight). We believe it indicates that the PHR had no part in the nuclear holocaust in Atlantia. Several conclusions can be drawn from this intelligence, however, it should be noted that given the Republic's customary mastery of manipulation, we can never be truly sure of anything that passes the lips of their agents.



REPORT #16 OF AGENT DELTA 28: EDEN PRIME, JUNE 29TH, 2671AD, D+388

+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F
Officers Eyes Only +++

I stood at my usual place among the Guard in the fetid palace's throne room, the lurking place of Salakahn. I'd killed several men to get to this point, the work of many weeks of necessary savagery. The 'Boss' preferred his bodyguards to be violent, sadistic but sheep-like in their deference to him, a part I'd been perfecting since I entered the palace by way of mutilation many months ago, simply to throw myself at the tyrant's feet.

Casting my eyes around the room more than my 'esteemed colleagues', I spotted the PHR delegation entering. Just as they did so, a deep rumbling passed through the room and a subtle rain of mortar dust fell from the ceiling. My real compatriots were getting closer to the city centre.

"Greetings, Great One" intoned Giselle, the delegation's spokeswoman.

"None of that obsequious crap, I thought we'd agreed to be honest with each other" replied Salakahn in his customary quiet but gruff tone.

"Fine. I'll be brief then. A pullout from the centre is impossible at this time. Our mission here is at a delicate and crucial stage... we need but a few more days to..."

"BE SILENT!" Salakahn roared in one of his signature and shockingly abrupt losses of composure - all the more effective due to their scarcity. This gave even the usually unscrupulous post-humans pause. "What you pretty things decide to do from this point on is your business. This city is lost and I am not such a fool to die for your little schemes. The colonial dogs are almost on us and I intend to turn the tables in my own way. This little pact between us has been entertaining, I'll admit, but I am not your pet. Get out of my sight or we'll see if your guts are as shiny as the rest of you."

This bald statement was delivered in decreasing volume but with increasing menace. The tyrant was at his most dangerous at these times and I gripped my weapon more tightly, in anticipation of the total anarchy that would ensue should the delegates turn on us. From what little I'd seen, I had absolutely no desire to fight these people - they are utterly lethal and far faster than we could ever be. A good job we outnumbered them ten to one, and for once in this infiltration I felt glad to be side by side with some of the most craven and twisted killers I'd ever encountered.

"Farewell for the present then. May we reacquaint ourselves with you in more... even circumstances one day." The delegates gave Salakahn a cursory glance and turned their backs on him in perfect and fluid unison, finally revealing the extent of their disdain for the despot in a moment of what I considered to be pure suicide. Astonishingly, Salakahn merely grunted and let them leave.

Once they had gone, Salakahn turned to the rest of us, "We have more important business to be about now our little

friends have left. My 13th Cabal have been busy preparing a small revenge for the Colonials in the past few days. I'm told we're ready to proceed. Kahn, I'd like you to keep six of my Guard here in the throne room with you to maintain a presence while we scarper. One of my doubles will stay here with you. It's crucial that the dogs believe I'm still sitting pretty here for now. Follow in 48 hours, or when they reach the gates."

"Your will," growled Kahn, a man who I'm sure had been resenting his place in the Guard for some time. At last, it seemed, he was getting some genuine responsibility. Perhaps this would make him more loyal in future.

"Ahh... your dedication is a delight to me. A promotion to a higher state will be forthcoming for you soon as a just reward for your loyalty... Now, let's be gone!"

As the tyrant departed, I turned out to be one of Kahn's chosen few to remain. I really had no choice but to stay for the sake of my cover and I now hope to rejoin the court after the retreat is complete. Perhaps I'll learn more of the plan while I'm here. Please ensure this encoded message gets to Naval Theory ASAP. I suggest it's forwarded to Gen. Foley expeditiously also, I know he still has his score to settle and he wouldn't want to miss the chance for pursuit. Delta-28 out.

SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

Eden VII is the only other planetary body in the system with any enemy presence remaining. While most of the titanium mines here are now under our control after subterranean dropship insertion missions there is still some way to go in securing final victory. It transpires that the Scourge have built a considerable subterranean network of strongpoints in the northern hemisphere that invite an attritional and grinding campaign that we can ill-afford.

After the Atlantia atrocity and the loss of troops to other fronts we have been forced to increase our victory projections into next year. We are simply spread too thinly to commit the kind of numbers needed to finally dislodge the aliens from the last rock in the system.

Given the lack of meaningful human Resistance here, Admiral Kronstein is currently petitioning the High Council to authorise a full nuclear saturation bombardment of the region, since all surface enemy missile halo assets have long since been pummelled into dust by conventional bombardment and no enemy ships remain. It is hoped that with sustained thermonuclear attacks that we can penetrate through to the underground facilities still crawling with Scourge, immolating them in their nests.

ORBITAL OPERATIONS

With all remaining Scourge fleet assets destroyed in the system, fleet actions have been rare. Much of Battlefleet Eden has been transferred to join Battlefleet Olympus for the continuing struggle there. Our picket fleet continues to perform outer marker patrol duties and orbital bombardment fire missions as required.

Fleet assets in the system have been kept at 35% above projected levels in order to deal with persistent Shaltari incursions. The Shaltari are sporadically and unpredictably conducting sorties over Eden Prime's northern hemisphere and occasionally over Eden VII, indicating that they still have some goal to achieve there. They are also launching hit and run attacks on our supply convoys and weaker Battlefleet elements.

Their piratical attacks are proving problematic, as we seldom have enough early warning to redirect our ships in time, spread thinly as they are. Losses are, however, within acceptable limits and these actions have amounted to little so far, only serving to keep more ships in system than intended.

PHR incursions are now a lot less common since the destruction of Atlantia, although many small surface extraction runs have slipped through our screen. Admiral Kronstein insists on vigilance and remains on high alert for Republic battlegroups; small wonder, since his own extensive injuries when the Battleship General Sherman was crippled by a PHR surprise attack over Eden VII on D+261.



ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

CITY OF STAR-CASABLANCA - EDEN PRIME

The heavy concentration of Scourge armour here is proving increasingly difficult to dislodge. Tank crews continue to dread a posting here since this is a city of narrow avenues and tight corners that play right into the hands of Scourge grav-tanks.

Protests, insubordination and even desertion are now commonplace in this sector. Attempts to improve morale and regain the initiative here are underway.

+++ The following section is redacted from the general report and only included for Classified level 5 or higher versions - High Council, Senior Admiralty and AHQ Staff Eyes Only +++

As of D+485, the Admiralty and the High Council have succumbed to repeated demands and passed an exception to our cherished 'Preserved City' policy, permitting the levelling of the centre by orbital bombardment. This is the least precious and most dilapidated city on the planet and thus the loss has been deemed acceptable in return for wiping out the high concentrations of Scourge here.

Currently we have the enemy boxed in to a confined area. In order to destroy the vast majority of this force it has been decided that a low-ionisation tactical nuclear strike will be the best way to proceed, as we do not have enough ships with conventional orbital bombardment capability left in system to supply the concentration of fire needed in so short a time period. Using the available assets would hugely increase the duration of a full conventional bombardment, and the Scourge would inevitably attempt to break out in desperation. Such a large force of mobile armour can no longer be permitted to exist on Eden Prime.

This operation will require the cooperation and ultimately extraction of the friendly (and highly effective) Resistance forces in the city. Since many are operating behind enemy lines, their job will be to disable or destroy all missile halo and anti-orbital assets in the city immediately before extraction, allowing the strike to get through. Timing will be crucial and the withdrawal must be rapid, as the removal of our noose from the enemy's throat for any significant time will give them an opportune window to react prior to their obliteration. Secrecy is of course essential as is the element of surprise - this operation is strictly need to know for the clearance level of this document only.

The Strike is tentatively scheduled for D+525 (awaiting final presidential approval) and preparations for the operation are well underway.



CITY OF NEW ATHENS - EDEN PRIME

The City of New Athens remains firmly in Scourge hands. Unfortunately, the loss of much of our ground strength in the desolation of Atlantia has left the UCMA incapable of launching an assault on this final enemy stronghold at this time. However, most of the surrounding settlements have now been captured and all that is required for the assault to begin is fresh troops from the colonies.

The Scourge are effectively trapped and isolated there at this time, without reinforcements from orbit and nowhere left to retreat to. With their backs to the frozen northern icecap, we can be sure of steep and determined opposition when the operation begins. Preliminary orbital bombardment is sadly unreliable due to the almost permanently adverse weather and the unusually powerful magnetic interference emanating from the pole.

At the time of writing the UCMA is massing for a ground assault, awaiting promised reinforcements from Titania. Due to the aforementioned environmental issues, the assault will need to be ground-based and supported by surface launched dropships.

The frequent interference by Shaltari forces in this sector is also a constant headache for our ground forces. Smaller elements are usually targeted and obliterated by superior alien forces which then vanish before a response can be brought to bear. It has been postulated that Shaltari aircraft can operate in such harsh conditions far more easily than our own, allowing their teleport gates to redirect their forces to places that we simply don't have the capability to follow safely. Their constant predations have undoubtedly delayed the assault here by many months and the capricious aliens are a factor that cannot be ignored.

The final assault on New Athens will undoubtedly be a hard fight in sub-zero temperatures. It is vital that the command structure maintains morale in the build-up, and that they respond to insubordination with harsh discipline. This will be a true test of our resolve and courage and our troops must not falter. Officers will be held responsible in the event of loss of morale or breakdown in command.

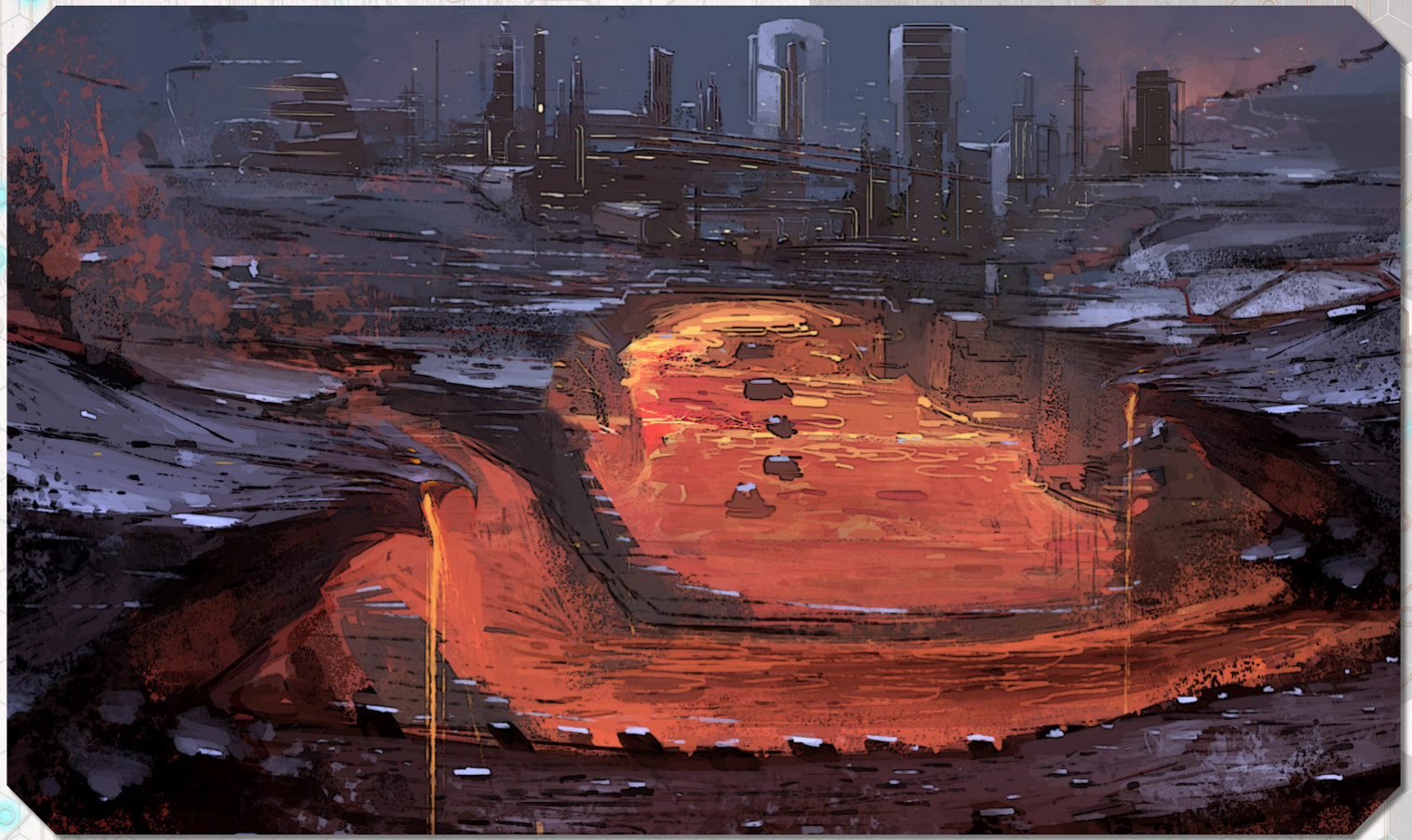
ODIN'S FOUNDRY - EDEN PRIME

Eden Prime's 2000 mile long mantle scar (also known as 'Odin's Foundry') is now largely in the hands of the UCM. Actions against remaining enemy forces can largely be considered a mop-up operation at this point.

The primary objective for our remaining forces here is to protect, reinforce and bring online our newly captured industrial assets in this sector. These will be crucial, providing the additional high quality minerals and metals sorely needed for the war effort, most notably for shipbuilding. Since the carnage over Olympus Prime, the replacement of lost tonnage has become a matter of urgency for the UCMF and the UCM as a whole.

The major complication in this is the presence of several extreme Feral Resistance groups in the area that oppose our occupation. Despite being of the same race, these degenerates view us as little different from the Scourge who recently held this region in their iron grip.

However, we have diplomacy at our disposal and we must succeed where the Scourge failed by bringing these savages under our control, lest they disrupt the vital flow of materials. Bands that are eager or willing to work with us will be crucial in aiding our efforts to find and, if need be, remove their less civilised kin.



TITANIUM MINES - EDEN VII

With the capture of the main Titanium mines the combat operations here are being wound down, although hit and run strikes from the Scourge's northern underground strongpoints are becoming increasingly common.

It must be hoped that Admiral Kronstein's plan for saturation nuclear strikes on these sites from orbit prove effective, should they receive approval from the High Council. In the meantime, garrison troops in the northern hemisphere should be on their guard for rapid surprise attacks from the Scourge.

SETTING GAMES IN THE EDEN SYSTEM (PHASE 3) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The Eden system is currently the closest system to absolute UCM control in the Reconquest; however, the fighting is far from over and recent events present new possibilities for players. In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, here are some more ideas for gaming in this system:

1) Games in Atlantia's nuclear wasteland - The city of Atlantia has just been almost completely annihilated by high-yield nuclear weapons at this point in the narrative. This presents a whole raft of possibilities for rescue and recovery missions, not to mention the awesome scenic possibilities.

3) Behind enemy lines in Star Casablanca - Attacks against missile halo ground assets (control stations, power relays, launchers etc.) make for excellent missions. The Aegis Orbital Defence Laser makes an impressive centrepiece for such games. Timed missions against the impending tactical nuclear strike would also work well here. Players could add a points penalty for the Attacker related to how many friendly units are still on the table at the end of the game.

4) The Battle for New Athens - This is currently shaping up to be the final full-scale ground battle of the war on Eden Prime. The Scourge are well entrenched here and won't go down without a hard fight! This city is based in the frozen north, making arctic themed tables highly appropriate. A fully winterised Sci-Fi city would make a stunning hobby project.

5) Odin's Foundry Counter-Insurgency - The savage Resistance groups based here provide interesting possibilities for themed armies - these guys are as feral as it gets! Since the UCM are now the occupiers of this region, their crazed fury will be directed at them. Don't forget the inspiring scenery building possibilities of a lava filled industrial nightmare!

6) Karl Foley vs Salakahn - The fact that the Tyrant of Atlantia slipped through his fingers (coupled with mass genocide of course) will make Karl Foley even keener to seek his reckoning with Salakahn. This ongoing rivalry could provide the base for a narrative campaign centred on these two famous commanders.

ELYSIUM SYSTEM

OCT 19TH, 2671AD, D+323



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

OVERVIEW

SURFACE OPERATIONS - ELYSIUM PRIME

Fighting in Elysium Prime's capital of Triticum is reaching a decisive stage. They have been denied reinforcements due to developments in other theatres, and the original combat deployment of 5 million troops is slowly beginning to suffer the effects of attrition and battle fatigue. Even so, our landing force remains 72% combat effective and is still deemed sufficient to conquer the rest of the planet in an acceptable timeframe. Further, the Elysium system's secondary planets have been in our hands since Phase 1 and are no longer included in military status reports (for more information, see separate reconquest integration, logistics and restructuring reports).

AHQ analysts are increasingly viewing this theatre as an example that will either vindicate or refute our projections and models. Only limited external or unforeseen factors are at work on the ground at this time and it is simply a case of whether enough troops have been committed to complete the task. While a clinical and detached analysis, war on this scale is an industrial, species-level conflict, and the numbers must tell.

Elysium remains a crucial Cradle World due to its vast food production capacity. While additional supplies are always welcome, the value of denying this resource to the enemy far outweighs our gains.

This objective was wholly achieved during the early stages of Phase 1 with the destruction of the Scourge fleet in the Elysium system, cutting off the rest of Scourge territory from this bread basket world. This is the main explanation for the lack of haste in completing the Reconquest here as other, more immediate problems exist in other systems. Exemplary generalship and steely resolve will have to take the place of limitless reinforcements to win the day here.

ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Enemy fleet assets in the Elysium system have been entirely neutralised and not a single Scourge ship is reported present. However, attacks from Shaltari ships are a persistent problem and even after almost a year in theatre Battlefleet Elysium has failed to bring the Shaltari to a meaningful void battle.

Tactics are improving however and coupled with the welcome delivery of several hundred fast frigates of mixed classes fresh from Niccolum's shipyards, it has been possible to keep the Shaltari at bay for now. The aliens' focus seems to be causing disruption and slowing our efforts to bring the campaign on the ground to an end. Supply ships are the most common targets and while these attacks result in little direct loss of life, they are certainly hurting our hard pressed troops on the ground.

ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

CITY OF TRITICUM - ELYSIUM PRIME

The massive concentrations of Scourge forces in the centre of the capital are under increasing pressure due to our encirclement tactics. UCM troops are now advancing on multiple fronts into the city itself and constricting Scourge held territory still further.

Cut off from supplies and without an escape route, Scourge forces there will be doomed to slow constriction and annihilation. The enemy obviously knows this and until recently has been launching periodic raids from outside the city to attempt to affect a breakout. These raids have ceased in recent weeks however, resulting in a general sense of unease and foreboding among some of our more experienced generals.

Recon patrols are being stepped up in anticipation of a massive enemy offensive to finally break their forces out of the city. Unfortunately, swift and lethal flights of Shaltari

Warspears have been downing an alarming number of recon aircraft recently, further adding to the sense of impending carnage without allowing us more specific knowledge on Scourge troop build-ups.

The prevailing attitude of AHQ is to take all necessary precautions against Scourge incursion and to prepare for a major counter-offensive in the coming weeks.

CITY OF GRANUM - ELYSIUM PRIME

Colonial forces have begun preliminary bombardment against Scourge positions in Granum; Elysium Prime's second city, and a focus for strong Scourge opposition. Ground emplacements and orbital assets are being employed in the bombardment, guided and designated by our local Resistance allies.

Unfortunately, their indispensable efforts to call in accurate fire have been disrupted by the crazed warbands of the Feral savage Gunnarr, the infamous Ferryman of Elysium. It seems this true psychopath is hell-bent on butchering all who attempt to assist the UCM. Whatever shred of strategic awareness this man possesses seems to have realized that our capture of the city will put an end to his grizzly playground once and for all.

Our ally's commander, the esteemed Jessie Adams, is assisting us as best she can in efforts to kill this madman, although it seems she has been trying herself for many years without success. A final reckoning between these two most juxtaposed leaders may be coming and AHQ will do all it can to assist.

In the meantime, Jessie's unrivalled knowledge of Granum's hotly contested tunnel system has proved invaluable in gaining solid intel of enemy forces deep inside the city itself;

a feat we could only attempt from orbit (a poor substitute for on the ground knowledge) due to heavy Scourge AA presence in the city.

SETTING GAMES IN THE ELYSIUM SYSTEM (PHASE 2) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

UCM activities have stalled somewhat in this theatre at this point in the narrative and are facing a difficult fight in the future without significant reinforcements. Although the strategic aim of this campaign (cutting the rest of Scourge territory off from this massive food supply) has already been achieved, this will be no comfort to the boots on the ground who must now dig deep to achieve final victory! In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, here are some more ideas for gaming in this system:

1) Enemy counter-offensive in Triticum - The Scourge are clearly planning a massive attack in an attempt to liberate their beleaguered forces pinned down in the capital. This is a good setting for large battles as well as specially designed missions themed around a possible break-out.

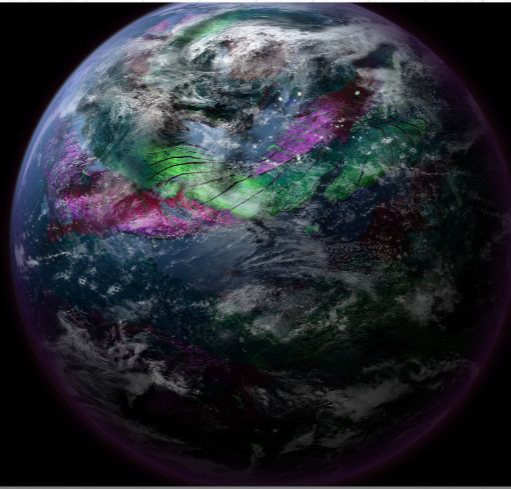
2) The assault on Granum begins - This is the last major city on Elysium Prime still in Scourge hands and represents a hard fight for the UCM. This is a good general setting for games using many different scenarios.

3) Gunnarr vs Jessie Adams - The almost lifelong rivalry between these two diverse characters is still ongoing. Jessie Adams will continue to attempt to put Gunnarr down for good, while he will try to slaughter his way through anything that moves. Games centred on these two famous commanders open up many interesting narrative possibilities.



SHANGRI-LA SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD, D+5



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

OVERVIEW

SURFACE OPERATIONS - SHANGRI-LA

The planet of Shangri-La was always projected to be one of the most difficult objectives for Reconquest forces. The dense vegetation makes rapid advances on the ground almost impossible, while the thousands of small spaceports provide the enemy with countless strongpoints to fortify.

Unlike other Phase 2 operations, our forces have been unable to confine the Scourge ground forces to localised areas. Instead, pockets of enemy units are everywhere, often well behind our lines. Such an outcome was inevitable, and factored into our plans, but this does not make the terrain any less challenging.

Dropship and bulk lander based operations are still the norm even after over 250 days in theatre, as they are the only viable means of movement. Indeed, AHQ have allocated the highest per-capita dropship ratio in the entire Reconquest to this campaign. Despite the challenges, our forces were progressing well and on schedule until D+245, when the situation in the void took an unexpected and inexplicable turn for the worse.

ORBITAL OPERATIONS

The battle for the void in the Shangri-La system was drawing to a close by D+230. Tenacious opposition from the Scourge garrison fleet was intense but ultimately doomed to fail due to our superior numbers and frequent resupply. Control of the void is always a crucial first step in any Reconquest campaign and the Admiralty was unswerving in its support for eradicating the enemy fleet despite the setbacks in the Olympus Theatre.

With the void war all but won, Battlefleet Shangri-La began preparation for a system wide hunter-killer sweep to find and eliminate all remaining enemy ships. Artfully executed Scourge hit and run strikes had become frequent as the confrontation became ever more asymmetric in our favour and the Admiralty had finally lost patience. This sweep would involve almost the entire Battlefleet in order to cast the net as wide as possible and give the enemy no room to escape to the outer marker and jump away.

Once the sweep was well underway on D+245, warning claxons sounded the approach of hundreds of unknown vessels around the system's outer markers. Battlefleet Shangri-La was at this point spread thinly throughout the system and poorly positioned to respond. Wiping out our remaining picket ships while punching through to Shangri-La itself, the largest single PHR fleet formation yet thrown against us was revealed. Their strike carriers immediately began landing ops on dozens of obscure locations simultaneously, overwhelming UCM and Scourge forces on the surface alike.

Ten days after their assault began, Battlefleet Shangri-La has as yet been unable to bring the PHR fleet to battle. It took several days to re-form into a viable large scale formation capable of taking on the massive PHR fleet without being picked off, and since then the enemy have been evading us masterfully. Strategists are increasingly of the opinion that they are not in system to destroy us directly, but rather for some other purpose. They could have easily exploited our wide positioning to destroy our entire fleet piecemeal, but seemed to choose not to.

The situation around the PHR dropsites on the ground is an entirely different story. Our forces there have been destroyed utterly and without mercy, as have those of the Scourge. Due to the presence of the PHR fleet we have been unable to respond to these concentrations with orbital bombardment or drops and it will instead be up to the UCMA and ground launched dropships to enact vengeance for these attacks.

There is evidence that the PHR are beginning to withdraw back to orbit at several locations, increasing pressure on us to respond and perhaps learn some truth as to the Republic's mission here before it is too late.

A side effect of this attack is that Scourge raiding battlegroups are still extant in the system, as our sweep had to be called off in order to respond. They will undoubtedly make us pay for this disproportionately and supply convoys and unarmed vessels should be on constant alert for surprise attacks.

SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

The system's two other habitable planets, Helen and Persephone, began as low priority targets due to their hostile flora and fauna and extensive Scourge anti-orbital setups. It was decided in Phase 1 that defeating these with conventional assault would be costly and would offer uncertain returns.

Neither planet was particularly productive in the pre-war years due to the hostile wildlife and it was unclear whether this had changed under Scourge occupation. Instead, it was decided that more on the ground intel was required and series of low-key MF-R insertions were approved in the early stages of the campaign.

These recon sorties have recently provided us with some invaluable intel and have forced us to reappraise and upgrade the value of both planets as strategic targets for Phase 2. Unfortunately, the unconscionably high fatality rate (even among the most elite MF-R teams) confirms that the wildlife is just as lethal as ever. Indeed, almost half of all un-armoured personnel dropped were poisoned, decapitated, crushed, eaten or otherwise maimed by these planet's deadly bioforms before they even observed a single Scourge.

The teams that did make it to their observer positions witnessed some shocking additions by the enemy. It seems that the Scourge are using Helen and Persephone as locations for massive growth hives for both Human and alien Scourge hosts. UCM astrobiologists theorise that the high oxygen content in the atmosphere coupled with other environmental factors somehow increase the success rate of Scourge rapid vat-based host growth from less than 10% to over 40%.

In addition, the hives were also being used as R&D facilities for converting some of the most lethal wildlife into new Scourge host types. Clearly, such abominable labs cannot be allowed to exist and as soon as these reports were in, AHQ began drawing plans to destroy these facilities.

With the fluid and evolving situation in the void, small scale, focused ground insertions have been chosen as the method to destroy these key locations as opposed to orbital bombardment, which has been deemed too risky at this time.

ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

SPACEPORT COMPLEXES AND PHR DROPSITES - SHANGRI-LA

We are currently focusing on countering the newly arrived PHR forces in and around their dropsites. Priority one is to neutralise the invaders, priority two is to ascertain the purpose of their incursions. Our top analysts are still in the dark as to the Republic's purposes in the war and this may be the first major opportunity to find out more, given the scale and duration of their campaign.

Previous attacks by PHR forces have generally been astonishingly rapid and localised, giving us little chance to respond.





This operation is far larger than anything that has come before and may just give us the time to gain some desperately needed intelligence. Efforts against the huge number of extant Scourge enclaves and redoubts on the planet are still of course ongoing and will continue despite the PHR presence.

We simply cannot afford to give the vile aliens time to regroup in the face of our unforeseen setback and we must maintain the pressure. The UCM still has the numerically superior force to both the Scourge and PHR combined and we should not be cowed into reactive actions only. Maintaining pro-active and offensive operations against the enemy is paramount to completing Phase 2 of the invasion here.

EXPERIMENTAL HIVE FACILITIES - HELEN AND PERSEPHONE

Full scale assault against these affronts to nature have been deemed too costly and initially planners turned to surgical insertion of elite teams to destroy the facilities from within. However, the experiences and unacceptable non-combat fatalities incurred by the recon teams forced a re-think. Instead of using un-armoured MF-R operatives, AHQ have turned to the new Heavy Hazard suit teams as the core of the infantry assault. Heavily armoured and completely enclosed, they would at least be proof against some of Helen and Persephone's poisonous animals, plants and fungi.

These troops will need armoured vehicle support for the insertion, as stealth is hardly the preserve of hulking armoured suits. As such, the scale of the planned operations has increased beyond the clandestine. Focused, surgical and rapid insertion by dropship is planned to commence as soon as the PHR fleet presence is dealt with and some friendly ships can safely be assigned to assist in the operations.

The very best pilots will be required and the approach will need to be long due to fearsome Scourge anti-orbital protection around the facilities. These missions have been declared 'volunteer only' and casualties are projected to be high.

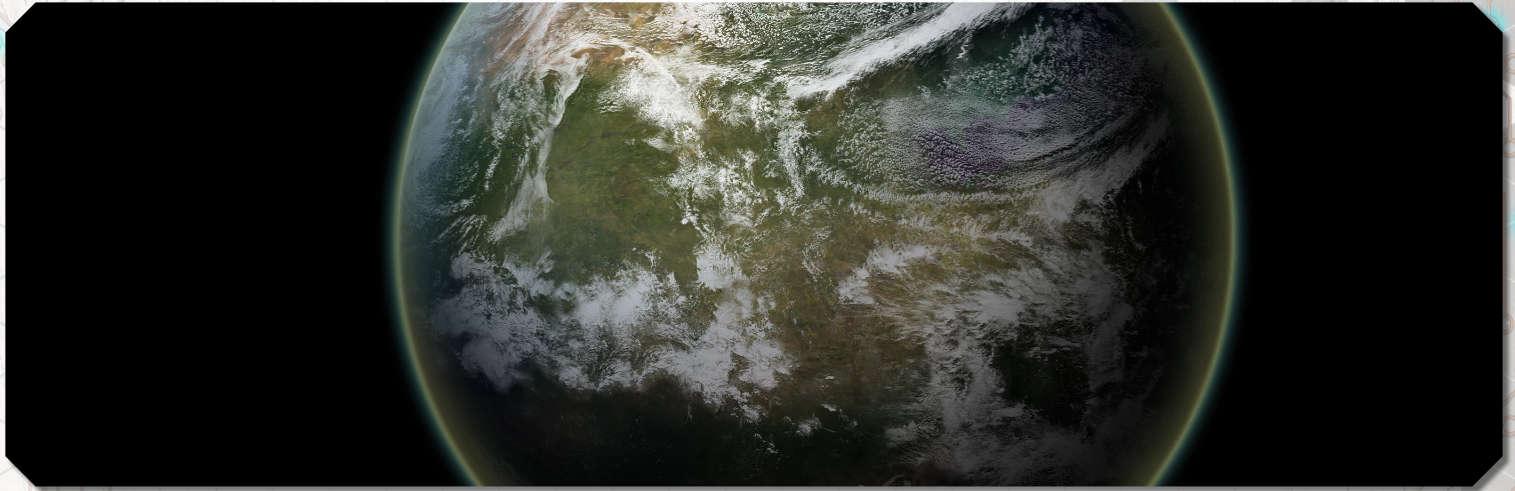
SETTING GAMES IN THE SHANGRI-LA SYSTEM (PHASE 2) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Ground combat in the whole system is still very much in flux, especially with the arrival of the PHR. In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, below are some more ideas for gaming in this system. Don't forget - every planet in this theatre opens up awesome jungle style modelling opportunities. Also, be sure to check out some of the new environmental rules later in this book - many of them are perfect for games set here!

- 1) The PHR attack! - This theatre has seen some of the heaviest PHR involvement in the entire Reconquest so far. They have a number of obscure objectives but at this point in the narrative they are most concerned with taking and holding their beachheads and searching for whatever they came for. The UCM and Scourge are sure to react to their incursions of course.
- 2) Intel gathering against the PHR - With this many Republic forces in theatre, it will be harder and harder for them to keep their activities secret. Attempts by all four other races to gather intel against them are likely to be intense and opens up many gaming possibilities.
- 3) Spaceport hopping continues - Despite the setbacks, the UCM still need to capture many of Shangri-La's spaceports.
- 4) Attacks on the Hives on Helen and Persephone - These attacks will be focused and fast but require full armoured support, making them ideal for games of DZC. These locations are perfect for some of the new environmental rules, not to mention the mega-fauna and flora outside the hives and the terrifying bio-mechanical nightmares in their interiors...

OLYMPUS SYSTEM

OCT 19TH, 2671AD, D-UNSPECIFIED



+++ Classified level 3 - Senate and Admiralty L3+ Staff Eyes Only +++

OVERVIEW

ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Orbital operations against the Scourge in this theatre are unfortunately still ongoing many months into the campaign. The voidspace over Olympus prime has since become the largest graveyard of military starships ever witnessed by mankind. Over a thousand vessels of frigate tonnage or above have met their demise here with truly staggering losses on both sides.

The initial engagement saw the majority of the devastation and lasted a full nine days - a record for a single fleet action. As Battlefleet Olympus was sent priority reinforcements from other theatres, the Scourge were equally willing to throw ships into the meat grinder. For some reason, they chose this battle to make a stand against us, representing the first major test for our fleet. Ultimately, we emerged victorious but badly mauled.

The Admiralty had always expected a major and decisive fleet engagement to take place in the first year of the campaign however, and such losses were deemed inevitable. Tales of daring actions and murderous struggles for the void are legion, but full details are reserved for the Admiralty's main report and are beyond the scope of this document to convey.

Some have denounced this battle as a pyrrhic victory and a cruel waste of ships, others hail it as the first full scale triumph against the Scourge on more or less equal terms. Other void battles in other theatres have been mostly one-sided affairs, with the enemy eventually bowing to inevitable defeat at the hands of our greater numbers. Unfortunately, after the First Battle of Olympus, we can no longer count on certain numerical superiority in the future, such were our losses. Naval Theory is confident that the enemy will also be feeling their casualties just as keenly after

such a titanic engagement.

Besides the loss of ships, the first major consequence of the battle was the rendering of Olympus Prime's low orbit into hazardous space. The sheer quantity of debris and wrecked ships now circling the planet make the use of small, lightly armoured voidcraft extremely unsafe. Unfortunately, this includes the UCMA's bulk landers and makes a mass landing of ground forces impossible at this time.

Since many of the derelicts were wrecked at combat speed (gravity nulled and well below unpowered orbital velocity), it is projected that most debris will safely burn up in the coming days and Olympus Prime's low orbit will likely be declared safe in less than two months, when landing ops can finally begin.

In the meantime, Scourge raiding parties remain a constant threat and waves of enemy reinforcements can and do arrive at any time. It appears that the Scourge are continuing to do all they can to prevent D-day on Olympus, although they have clearly switched tactics from full scale battle to naval skirmish and hit and run attacks. Even so, Battlefleet Olympus is still indisputably the largest of our fleets and is well prepared to face whatever the aliens have to throw at us.



SURFACE OPERATIONS - OLYMPUS PRIME

We have begun landing small expeditionary forces by Strike Carriers and Lysanders as a preparatory phase of operations before the main landing assault begins. These vessels are armoured well enough to punch through the debris field acceptably and are currently the only option for landing troops, although they cannot carry the numbers needed for a true invasion. Instead, their objectives are to destroy ground based defence batteries and orbital defence grid control stations in focused strikes, withdrawing once successful, as we cannot maintain a beachhead. As the element of surprise is long since lost to us in this theatre, preparations ahead of the invasion must be thorough and meticulous as we can no longer hope for an uncoordinated response from the enemy.

Protracted orbital bombardment is still not a viable option due to all the interference from the debris field. Additionally, the fact that parts of Olympus Prime's potent orbital defence grid are still operational and in enemy hands makes holding station in low orbit hazardous in the extreme.

In addition, an elite recon force has been dispatched to the capital city of Asphodel to observe and, if necessary, intervene in the ongoing PHR assault against Scourge forces there. We have been aware of this incursion since the early days of the campaign and Naval Theory is keen to gain some hard intel on the ground. It seems that the local Resistance are almost exclusively working with the Republic, so we cannot count on their support or local knowledge.

What is certain is that with our naval blockade firmly in place, the PHR ground forces are now trapped in the city with no hope of extraction or reinforcements. If there was ever an opportunity to discover the truth of the post-human's enigmatic part in the war, this may be it.

SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

The Olympus system contains three other planets with viable objectives on the surface, Olympus II, V and IX. These were all reclassified as Phase-2 objectives early in the campaign due to the difficulties faced in initiating D-Day on Olympus Prime.

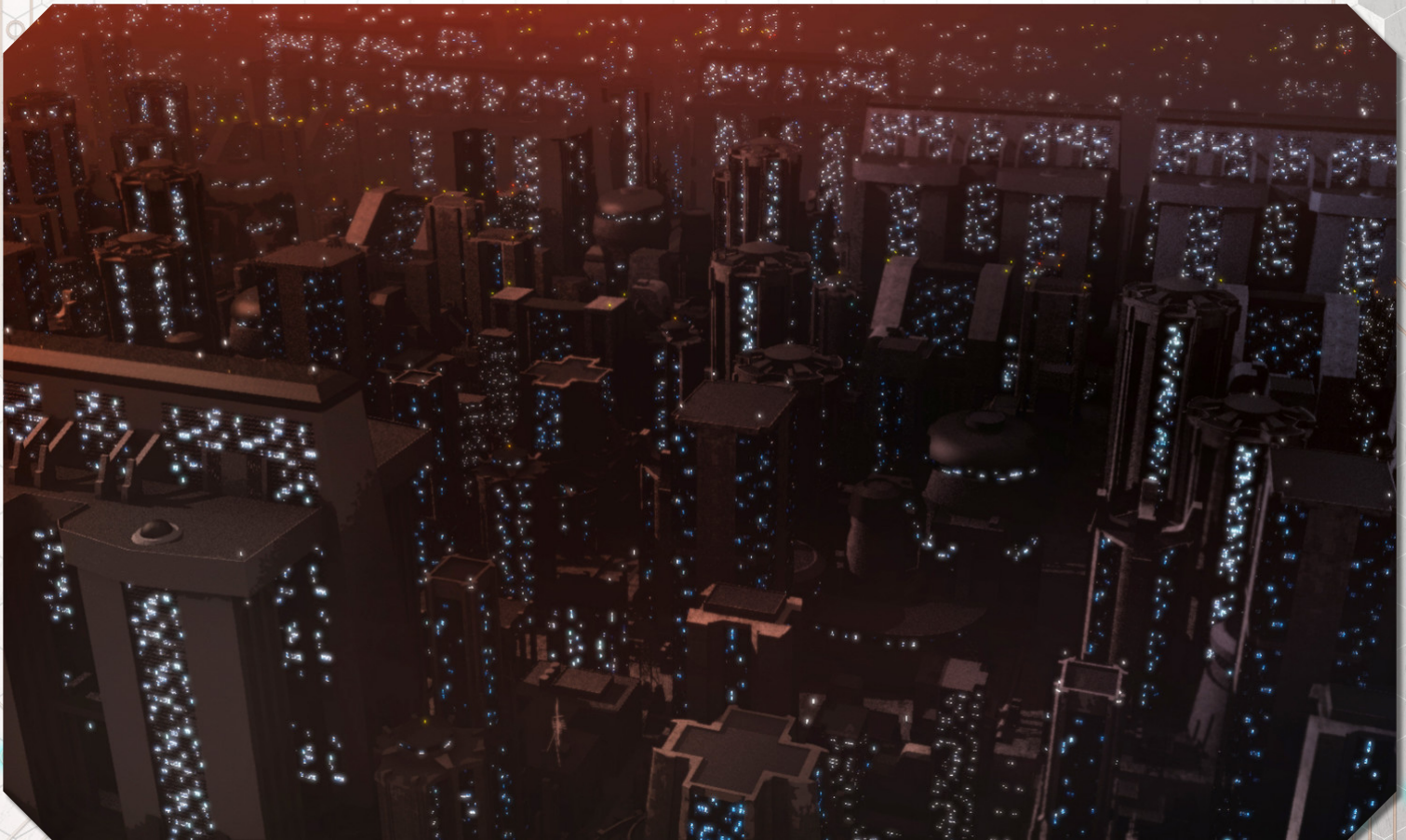
With the Scourge garrison fleets above these planets decimated, we have begun orbital bombardment preparations ahead of future landings. None of these worlds have a defence grid anything like as formidable as the one over Olympus Prime and therefore we can conduct such operations with relative impunity.

ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

PREPARATORY PHASE LANDING OPERATIONS - OLYMPUS PRIME

Over thirty small, independent landing ops are currently in progress across the surface of Olympus Prime to help prepare the ground for the full scale invasion. They are charged with a variety of objectives including destroying defence batteries, control stations and power sources, in addition to disrupting enemy supply columns and conducting reconnaissance.

These landings are usually in urban or industrial zones and cannot be sustained for more than a few days at a time as any coordinated enemy response is lethal and overwhelming. These operations are projected to continue for at least the next 60 days as the fleet waits for the orbiting debris field to clear.



INTELLIGENCE GATHERING - ASPHODEL CITY, OLYMPUS PRIME

A Marine Force Recon detachment with limited light vehicle support is currently en-route to Asphodel to ascertain the mysterious purpose of the PHR incursion here. They have orders not to engage unless fired upon and must rely on stealth and careful movements to avoid detection.

There are currently six combat hotspots spread seemingly at random throughout the city, in what would generally be designated as low-priority zones in a UCM invasion. The detachment will be split into six teams on arrival to reconnoitre each separately as numbers will be of little help if detected. Extraction of the MF-R teams will be by Raven A/S stealth modified dropships at obscure outskirt locations on Nov. 5th, enemy presence permitting.

ESCC FLEET YARDS - OLYMPUS PRIME ORBITALS AND DEFENCE GRID

The landing of ground troops inside the cavernous interiors of Olympus Prime's vast orbital installations is still ongoing, but progressing well. Such assaults on orbitals are never easy and losses have been proportionately higher than most ground drops. Angles of approach and strategy have necessarily been slow and methodical, as only the outskirts of enemy held orbital reefs can be assailed without our assets being obliterated by overlapping fire arcs.

It is estimated that 35% of the orbitals are now under Colonial control with a further 25% necessarily destroyed or disabled. Capture or deactivation of the remaining 40% is a priority one objective. The importance of this cannot be overstated; such is the potency of Olympus Prime's defence grid that if even 10% remains in enemy hands, landing force casualties during a full scale invasion will be too high for AHQ to accept.

ORBITAL DEFENCE GRID CONTROL - STYX MOON LANDING OPERATIONS

The assault against the underground defence grid control station of Styx (Olympus Prime's lone moon) is in its final stages. This enormous facility is cut over half a mile deep into lunar rock and has presented a challenging zero atmosphere, low grav combat environment. It has cost considerable time and lives to fight our way through to the main chambers and defence has been ferocious.

Deployment of heavy armour to the very core of the station is now underway; enemy resistance remains fierce and of course no fire support can be brought to bear from orbit due to the depth.

Victory is anticipated in a minimum of two weeks' time and this projection does not cover any unknown means the Scourge may have of bringing reinforcements to the battle. AHQ is poised to react if necessary, as the timing of this operation is vital since the parts of the grid that can be shut down with its capture will enable the next major phase of landings on the orbitals themselves.

SETTING GAMES IN THE OLYMPUS SYSTEM (PREPARATORY PHASE) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

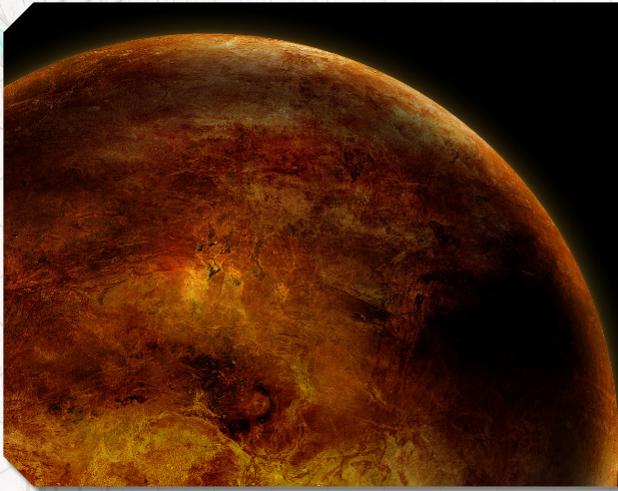
Most UCM troops are still stuck in space and unable to launch a full invasion; however, a large number of smaller operations are underway which all make for great settings for DZC games. In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, here are some more ideas for gaming in this system:

- 1) Preparatory Landings - Unlike most other theatres, the element of surprise is entirely lost here. As such, the UCM will need to prepare the ground for their invasion carefully by attempting to take out ground defences and control stations. Some custom made scenery would be highly characterful - think of giant anti-orbital guns several feet long, the kind of epic scenery 10mm scale wargaming was made for!
- 2) Intel gathering in Asphodel city - This presents another opportunity for the UCM to learn more of the PHR's purposes, but since it's well behind enemy lines in a city crawling with Scourge, it will need to be covert. Inventing some house rules would be a good start here and this setting is ideal for smaller games.
- 3) The battle for Styx Moon - This provides an interesting setting for underground combat in a lunar, low-grav setting, making it ideal for using some of the new environmental rules. It also opens up some interesting ideas for scenery building as these underground spaces are vast - easily large enough to fly dropships into!



AARU SYSTEM

AARU, OCT 19TH, 2671AD, D-UNSPECIFIED



UCMA EXPEDITIONARY FORCE REPORT: AARU, OCT 2ND, 2671AD

+++ Classified level 4 - Senate, Admiralty and AHQ
Officers Eyes Only +++

After over eight months of operations in the bowels of this unique planet, our sponsored insurgency against the Scourge is progressing well. Numbers of surviving Resistance groups are highly satisfactory and more are joining the cause every week. Due to the subterranean biosphere environment, it has been possible for millions of free humans to live quietly and largely unmolested by the Scourge during the long years of occupation. An unusual complication of this kind of existence is the people's extreme aversion to sunlight, as most of them have rarely witnessed it. Instead, they live their lives by the dim light of the Aaruvian fauna's bioluminescence.

It is now well understood that the Scourge do not like to operate far from their larger constructs when natural barriers (such as rock) obscure them to whatever passes for communication between the Scourge. Reports of cells fleeing from them and finding safety with pursuit broken in deeper regions are commonplace.

Another contributing factor in our continuing success is the actions of the Shaltari, who are attacking the Scourge mercilessly in multiple sectors. Such engagements are large and we cannot hope to get involved directly with our currently lamentable lack of armour or direct support capability. Instead, we are focused on improving the coordination of desperate Resistance groups and at least we are very well provisioned with high tech comms gear. With this increased cooperation, we have begun attacking enemy supply routes, materiel stores and ammunition dumps, inflicting massive damage with comparatively few losses.

We have yet to ascertain any special military or historical significance for Aaru other than its obviously unique geography and biology, beyond that of its high mineral

content (shared with all of the Cradle Worlds). The Shaltari obviously value it highly; however, the Scourge seem to have been siphoning some troops and ships away from Aaru to other theatres in recent months, perhaps due to UCM activities elsewhere. Despite this, current projects suggest that the Shaltari will do little more than frustrate and hamper Scourge operations, as they simply do not have the numbers to fully displace them.

We understand that the apparent military value of this planet is limited in the eyes of the High Council, but we (that is to say myself and the other expedition officers) humbly request, once again, greater materiel support. We are inflicting massively disproportionate damage to the Scourge here, more perhaps than in any other theatre of the Reconquest. That we are achieving this attrition rate with almost no armoured support and very few supplies is a testament to the courage of my men and that of our stalwart Resistance allies.

We beseech you to give this theatre the support it needs, and to send us greater logistical and armoured support as soon as is humanly possible. I find it hard to believe that the Scourge will tolerate our activities much longer, and I fear that the tide may turn very soon without more men. Capture of this Cradle World will be far more difficult for mankind in the future if we lose our key beachheads and the backing of local allies.

Yours, General J. Church, Officer Commanding, Aaru Expeditionary Force.

ARMY INTELLIGENCE MEETING REPORT EXTRACT: FERRUM, OCT 12TH, 2671AD

+++ Classified level 5 - High Council and Senior AHQ/
Admiralty Staff Eyes Only +++

On the Subject of the Aaru campaign,

The High Council, AHQ and the Admiralty are

unanimously delighted with the progress that has been possible on Aaru. Gen. Church is clearly doing an excellent job and should be fast tracked for promotion to Field Marshal in future.

Unfortunately, the difficulties of landing meaningful quantities of armoured units into such topography with zero possibility of preliminary bombardment are hard to overestimate. All serious enemy assets are placed well below the surface and will prove deeply challenging to displace since the human forces here during the original Scourge invasion managed to hold out far longer than on any other Cradle World before succumbing, and resistance numbers in the theatre are unusually high, these advantages must be maximised. Unless the General furnishes us with a more pressing reason to allocate resources disproportionate to this theatre's importance we recommend the continuation of the asymmetric warfare and sponsored insurgency policy until the latter stages of the Reconquest.

+++ Classified level 4 - Senate Admiralty and AHQ Officers Eyes Only +++

The attached document(s) serve the purpose of illustrating the state of the war in the Aaru theatre and we feel that little more needs to be added within the scope of this report. Active combat operations are detailed in brief below.

ACTIVE SUB-SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

GUERRILLA WARFARE - ALL HABITABLE ZONES, PREDOMINANTLY SOUTHERN HEMISPHERE

Raids against soft targets and crucial enemy infrastructure are still ongoing. Forces in such attacks are typically comprised almost exclusively of Resistance forces with minimal armoured support and limited Colonial presence in a support capacity.

The aim of this insurgency campaign is primarily to prepare the ground ahead of a full scale invasion. This will be achieved by slowly weakening the enemy's infrastructure and capacity to react cohesively to threats by targeting communications and logistics.

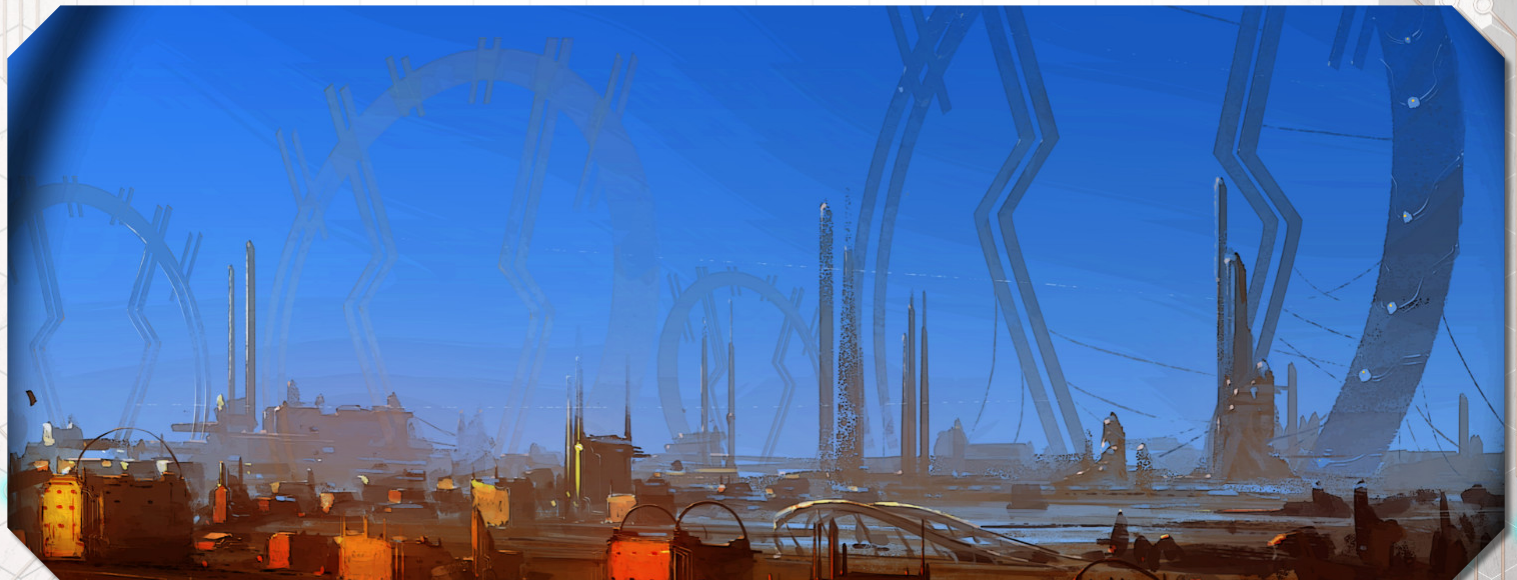


Larger expeditionary forces will then be dispatched to destroy harder targets, such as the sunken surface defence batteries and subterranean power nodes. However these operations are projected to be many months - if not years - away due to Aaru's second-tier strategic significance in the wider conflict.

The second purpose of the insurgency is to maintain the pressure on the enemy to keep as many hostile troops on Aaru as possible. The constant harassment from Resistance groups is projected to hold a significant quantity of Scourge fighting units in place, greatly aiding our more pressing campaigns in other theatres. This may seem callous but AHQ intelligence believes such considerations will be vital for eventual victory.

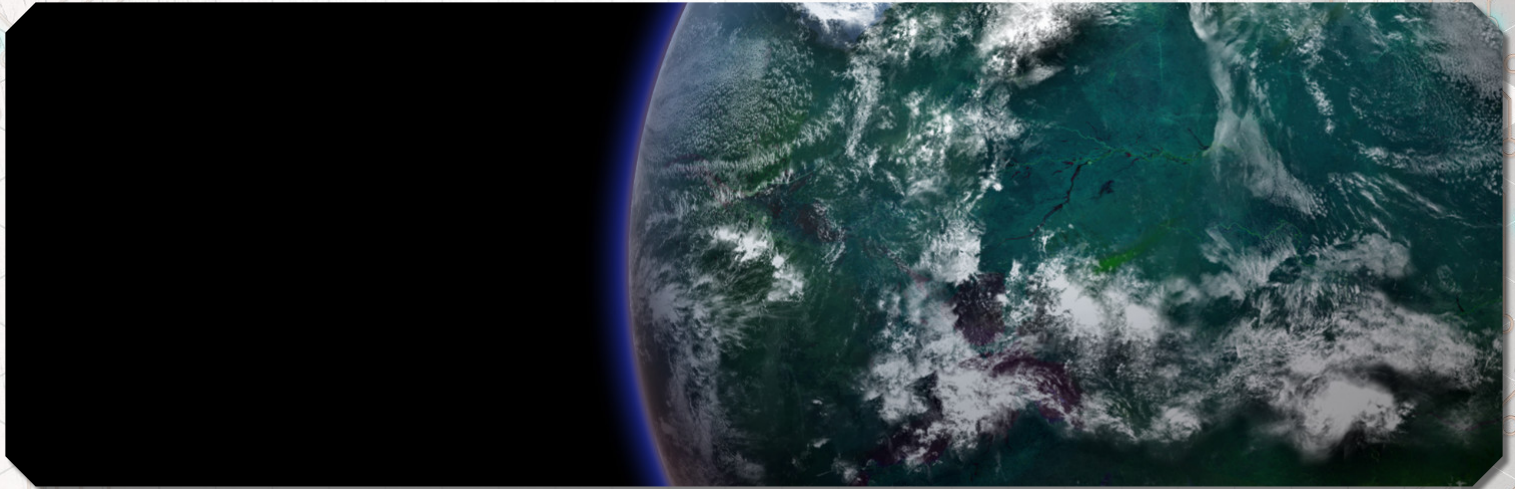
SETTING GAMES ON AARU - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Aaru has changed the least of all the Cradle Worlds in the last 250 days of the narrative. The UCM still has the same aims and is still working with similar (inadequate) resources. As suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, this planet offers some unique modelling opportunities for some truly inventive tables, such as a barren desert above and a verdant subterranean world beneath.



ASGARD SYSTEM

OCT 19TH, 2671 AD



+++ Classified level 6 - High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel Eyes Only +++

As you are no doubt aware, the expeditionary force we sent to Asgard were betrayed by their erstwhile allies in the Resistance during the early stages of their mission, almost certainly due to the machinations of the PHR. All nodes on Asgard ceased to function almost as soon as this took place and only a single UCM vessel, the heavily damaged Lysander class lighter Leprechaun was able to escape to the outer marker and jump back to the Colonies to bring us a report.

Since that time, no nodes have been reactivated in the system, making a rescue mission or deployment of reinforcements impossible for the moment. However, a lone ship of antique design was detected just over a month ago slowly drifting into Niccolum voidspace.

Scans revealed a pre-war beacon identifying the vessel as the Proud Servant, a private foldspace yacht once registered to the Asgard system. A boarding party found only a single, long dead man at the helm who had clearly succumbed to blood loss from a slash wound most likely from a fragment of shrapnel dislodged by shipfire. He was identified as Corporal Ryoto Aramaki of the Army Air and Space Corps, formerly a Condor dropship pilot. The only thing he carried with him besides his sidearm was a hastily recorded audio log, the transcript of which I enclose below:

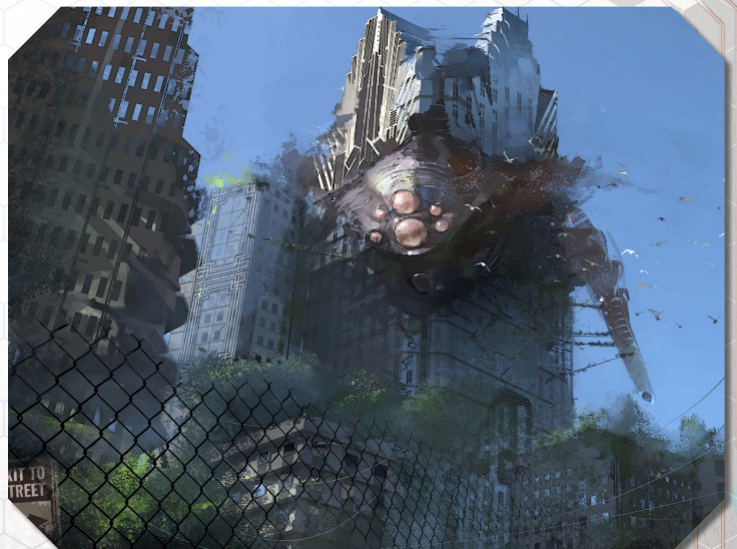
This is Colonel Samuel S. Helburn of the UCMA, highest ranking survivor of the Asgard Expeditionary force, date Jan 31st, 2671.

I have roughly 5000 combat effective men plus significant armour reserves remaining of the original force. A good number I reckon, given the circumstances. I'm in the process of withdrawing into the swamps to the North of Odinsburg, where we hopefully won't be a factor worth pursuing to those Republic bastards who set us up and the scum fighting with 'em. I'm sorry to have to report the loss of 3000 men, half our tanks and almost all our heavy dropships in the past 24 hours.

Resistance forces still loyal to us have permitted the use of a precious asset, a foldspace capable atmo-yacht. Apparently they've been storing her beneath the surface since the Scourge invasion. It's directly below our current position and we're under heavy fire. We're attempting to hold for long enough to get the engines up. She's rusty, but hopefully she'll fly and be too small to bother the Jellyheads.

We're aware that the nodes here are down, but I can input the code keys into the drive manually via encrypt-key to allow an accurate jump to the shipyards at Niccolum, that way at least this log might make it to the eggheads at Theory. Our node codes stay secure, even if it does mean I must be one of the last to leave. I'm the only officer left ranked high enough to have 'em and there's no damn way I'm giving them to anyone else, can't say people can blame me after what we've just been through.

Since the damn nodes are down, this'll be a one way trip for whoever goes. I'm staying of course, my troops need me. Breaking past the Scourge picket and whatever the PHR might have up there will be dangerous, so no point in sending more than one. Corporal Aramaki has volunteered and who am I to argue? He's got three kids back home and he's the best pilot I've got.



Short intel primer - PHR forces are in league with most of the local Resistance, who are themselves very well equipped. All our Strike Carriers were wrecked by PHR surprise attack and a few of our Lysanders were dashing to the outer marker last we heard. Hope those poor souls got out and that you know all this already. Our base will be the swamps about five clicks North of Odinsburg for now - no promises we won't have to move though.

We've deactivated our transponders and are using no distress beacons as I'm sure those techy Republic types will trace us easy if we leave 'em on. We'll be listening out for friendlies though so make some noise if anyone can come back for us. That last bit will be down to us I guess. Primary and only objective will be to find and reactivate a node or two so we can bring the green fury of the UCMA down on 'em!

We survived the attack, and we'll keep fighting. Colonel Sam Helburn, signing off.

The primary value of Col. Helburn's efforts is to inform us that there are some UCM personnel on Asgard left to extract, should we get a chance to affect a rescue.

As the Colonel states, it will be down to them to reactivate a node, otherwise there will be no possibility of returning to the Asgard system. In future, the immediate dropping of void based stealth nodes on arrival in a new system will be mandatory.

Failure to comply will trigger an immediate court martial of the most senior officer present. We simply cannot rely on old, surface based nodes - nor can all apparently 'friendly' Resistance groups be trusted. Further measures will need to be taken in future to ensure against such treachery.

Corporal Ryoto Aramaki was buried in space with full military honours and has posthumously been awarded the Fortitude Star, the highest honour for bravery in the service of the Colonies. Let us hope his sacrifice was not in vain. An MF-R rescue team is on constant readiness and prepped for immediate jump should a node be reactivated.

SETTING GAMES IN THE ASGARD SYSTEM - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Although the planet is currently inaccessible to the Colonies, the UCM does have troops there, engaged in a desperate struggle for survival against multiple races. In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, here are some more ideas for gaming in this system:

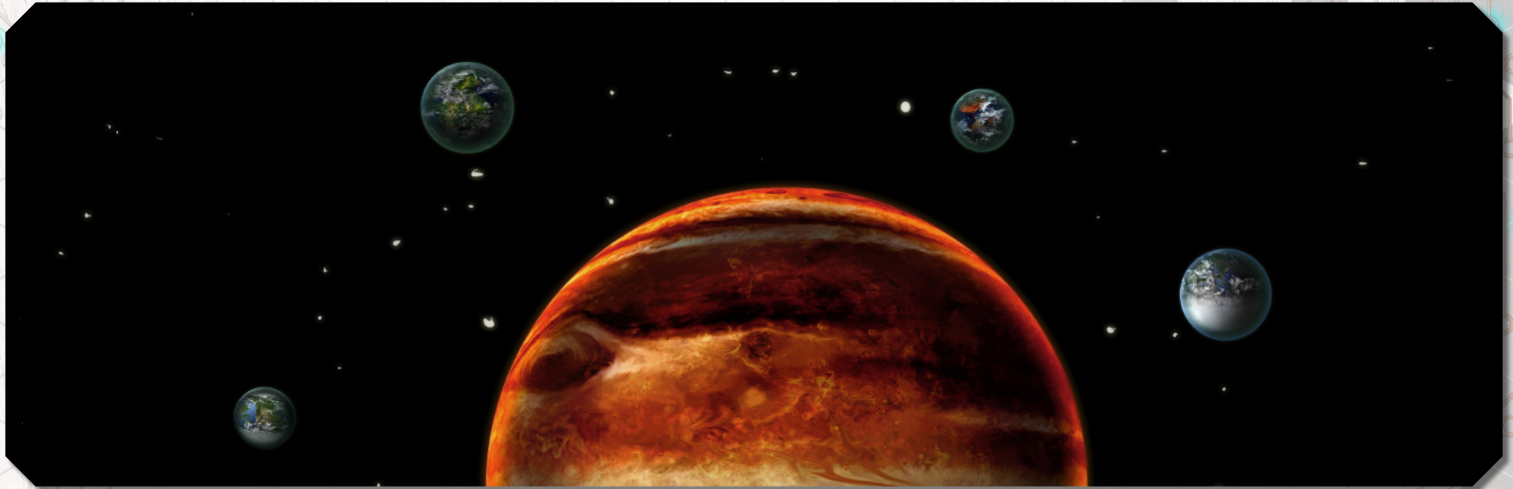
1) The Exploits of Colonel Helburn - This character is a brand new playable Famous Commander introduced in this book (rules can be found later in the book, in the UCM Units section). His struggle to survive against the odds and to reactivate a foldspace node to bring in reinforcements will be crucial to the future of this theatre. Building a campaign around this character - possibly with finite resources - would be a good starting point.

2) Premeditated betrayal - Setting games around the premise of Resistance allies turning on UCM forces would be an interesting basis for games and allow for some unusual deployment options. Perhaps a few Resistance battlegroups can deploy right next to the UCM in an unbalanced match-up with a small PHR force, only for them to turn on their allies!



TALOCAN SYSTEM

SEPT 28TH, 2671 AD



+++ Classified level 7 - UCMF Supreme Admiral, UCMA Supreme Marshal, Office of the President and Naval Theory authorised personnel Eyes Only +++

Madam President,

I have some more information for you concerning the Tlalocan system. I'm maintaining Level-7 classification for now as recent intelligence leaks suggest that a PHR spy is still at large on the High Council. It's still far from clear what kind of threat the Republic poses to us or what their purposes are, but I have recently received a report back from MF-B Team-9.

This is one of the Black-Ops units we dispatched to ascertain the fate of Team-5, originally charged with following PHR activities on the Tlalocan Moons.

Unfortunately, we have no word on the fate of Team-6, which was sent along with Team-9. Their supplies are due to last out for another few months at least and MF-B teams run dark as a matter of routine so I do not think we need to be concerned as yet. Knowledge that this theatre is even open to us at all is strictly 'need to know' for now and I think we should keep it that way for the foreseeable future.

I enclose a copy of Team-9's most recent report in redacted form (logistical details and full statistics omitted) and I will follow with my analysis in brief.

**ARMY INTELLIGENCE MEETING
REPORT EXTRACT: FERRUM, OCT
12TH, 2671 AD**

+++ Classified level 6 - High Council and Senior AHQ/
Admiralty Staff Eyes Only +++

The full scale PHR invasion of the Tlalocan moons seems to be entering its final stages, what we would term as Phase-3. It is certainly a sight to behold and quite unlike anything else occurring anywhere in the Reconquest. The numbers the Republic are bringing to bear here are

unprecedented - we estimate 30% of the personnel and 60% of the materiel of a typical UCM invasion, which are numbers enough for this foe. The Scourge are pinned into several small pockets now and are being pounded by relentless conventional orbital bombardment and ground artillery fire. We estimate that all meaningful Scourge presence will be purged from the Moons in less than three weeks from the time of writing.

In already secure areas, the Republic is busy constructing surface structures and orbitals at a breathtaking rate - objectively amazing to behold. Unfortunately, this will make the Moons virtually impregnable to anything less than a full scale Eden Prime level invasion at our current tech capability. On that subject, we have captured several fascinating pieces of PHR equipment and have a small collection of bodies aboard for autopsy, which will be of particular interest to the Science Division. We will be making a delivery of these finds in a few weeks time, once we have retrieved our remaining personnel from the surface. Our supplies are running low and a return trip to Niccolum will be needed soon in any case.

Unfortunately, I must report our failure in locating Team-5 or learning anything about their fate. They seem to have disappeared without a trace. However, MF-B teams are of course adept at precisely that, so there is a strong possibility that they are still alive down there. If that's the case, the intel they must have by now would be a prize indeed. As per standing orders, we have made no attempt to make contact with Team-6, which is operating entirely independently from us. Perhaps they have had more luck in finding Team-5.

We have scheduled our return to Niccolum for Oct. 12th, surface extractions permitting. If these run into difficulties we have enough supplies to last us comfortably until the end of the year. Nerves, however, are wearing thin among the non-MF-B ship crew. The proximity of such a massive and frankly more advanced fleet is making them jumpy. Despite our top of the line stealth capabilities we all believe that we cannot hope to evade detection here forever. For myself and the other officers, we're trained for worse than

this. This place gives me the creeps though (if you'll excuse the expression), I must admit. Something unique is going on here, I'm sure of it and I wish we knew more. Await further developments when we have them. It's getting increasingly dangerous to send foldspace communications back to base due to the ever closer PHR patrol sweeps, so time of next transmit is uncertain.

Yours,

Capt. Abdul Kane (MF-B9)

I concur with Cap. Kane in that this indicates the importance of the Moons to the PHR. The Republic has attempted nothing like this anywhere else and I admit to sharing an intense curiosity as to their purpose(s) there. Of course, it renders the possibility of a full scale invasion totally out of the question for the moment.

Frankly, we have our hands full with the Scourge and opening another front against a new and mysterious enemy would be foolhardy. Until we know more, I'm forced to conclude that we must accept Republic control of the system for the present.

It does however represent the very best intelligence gathering option we have against the PHR. I suggest assigning at least two more MF-B teams to the task. Teams 11 and 13 are prepped and ready to go after their highly successful tour in the Elysium System. Secrecy is paramount and we must hope that any PHR spies are outside this information bubble. Perhaps the physical intel Team-9 is due to bring back will help us find ways of identifying Republic aligned technologies and/or giving us ways to utilize them ourselves. I await your approval to brief and dispatch the teams.

Your servant as always,

Admiral Chang, Director, UCMF Theories Dept.

[TECHNICAL NOTE - FOLDSPACE

COMMUNICATIONS: This is currently the only way of sending information faster than light speed and of communicating in real time with a recipient in another system. These function by using a FTL capable ship's drive to open a limited foldspace rupture, through which data can be sent. This ship must be in a position where a jump is possible to transmit (i.e. at or beyond the outer marker of planetary bodies). This represents a severe limitation for ground forces, as a friendly ship must be on station to relay their signals, should the need to communicate beyond their own system arise.]

Master Sergeant Sian Carrow of MF-B13 paced the deck of the Silent Blade in a furious temper. She'd stormed out of the briefing for their next mission rather than lash out at that sanctimonious little insect from Theory once he'd done explaining why the whole damn Battlefleet wasn't jumping to Tlalocan right now. She'd had no idea, none, that the Moons were even accessible to them and even less that those PHR scumbags had made them their nest. Nest, that was the word, a coven of murderous vipers and the brass knew it, and still wouldn't bring the hammer down on their asses. Turned out the Republic was up to something massive and we were just going to sit back, take pictures and bring back a few souvenirs. A single hot tear splashed off the deck as she stopped pacing. It really wasn't helping.

Ever since she lost her brother to the betrayal on Asgard, she'd vowed to make the Republic pay. Nothing left to bury even, she didn't even know how he died. KIA against Post Human Republic ground forces in Odinsburg, Asgard Prime, no remains recovered. That was it (plus the generic 'service to mankind' bit of course). All she'd gotten from command by way of notice or explanation. The bastards would pay... She'd killed plenty of Scourge so far in this war, oh how she wanted to wring a few post-human necks... maybe she'd feel better then. She doubted it. It would never be enough.





She abruptly turned on her heels and left the empty rec room. Someone else would be along soon and she didn't want any of them to see her like this - tough girl image to maintain and all that. She'd go to gym 3, that would do. By far the worst one on the ship, with dust covering most of the equipment in there, she'd be alone to seethe in private.

As she began a round of bench presses, she considered what she might do. They were on top level isolation from the moment that briefing had finished, so no chance whatsoever to get this information out there. She couldn't be the only one that'd just let this slip by with no protest. There'd be riots on the streets of Aurum if the people knew, no love for the PHR there either, that's for sure... No, even if she could let the facts out, she wouldn't. She'd been trained for Black Ops, this level of security had to mean something. Her mind wasn't right at the moment, not balanced, not thinking straight, boiling over, that's all. Just breathe.

What she could do here and now was make damn sure to remind the rest of the team what the post-humans did to the likes of them, 'inferior beings' as they'd no doubt say in a maddeningly calm voices. She'd sow, nurture and mature the seeds of good old righteous hatred among the team, so if they did (oh glorious hope) get a chance to fight some of them, the guys would fight with full, honest rage. She smiled to herself... one of the guys... they were all guys in MF-B really, even if almost half of them were girls.

On her 37th lift of the weights, she felt a light prick on her neck. A normal person wouldn't pay attention to something so trivial when pumping iron and sweating buckets, but she was MF-B, not some farmboy from the Legions. She dropped the weight and spun her head round, eyes on stalks. Definitely no one in here and no way they could have got out in a few split seconds. She took a breath and touched her neck, a tiny spot of blood coming away on her fingertip. Weird... a bug maybe, must have been.

After a few more bench presses, something felt 'off'. A little light headed maybe... some tingling in the legs. She hadn't warmed up before this exercise, just got right on with it to work off the anger. That must be it... maybe a drink of water. As she walked to the corner fountain, she stumbled,

her left foot jarring oddly and her balance all screwed up. Great, just great... back to her bunk, not the damn infirmary, she couldn't face the sheer embarrassment of that. Some R&R, read her book maybe, calm down.

She barely made it from the room before her legs gave out from under her. As she crumpled to a heap on the floor of the empty corridor, she cast her eyes up for cameras. Someone would see and come to get her, hang the embarrassment. She was scared now. Noticing that all the cameras were pointing the wrong way, scared was suddenly no longer adequate. She'd been shot once, got concussion during training so often it was normal. This was SO much worse than that. Total loss of muscle control, she couldn't move an inch.

Suddenly, an unseen and powerful pair of hands grabbed her collar from behind and started to drag her along the corridor. She couldn't move her head at all, or her eyes. Vision was starting to grey out round the edges too, no chance of seeing who this guy was. Abruptly, she was pulled up and tossed into a small box of a room. "A necessary evil it seems. I'm sorry." Said a neutral voice behind her as the heavy door slowly closed. A REALLY heavy door. She could still think... through tunnel vision, she could suddenly see a red light sweeping round and round the little room over and over again, doubling her compulsion to throw up. By the red glow, she could make out the label 'Voidlock 12, Deck 2' just as a second door in front of her slammed open, decompression ripping her into the deathly embrace of cold, empty space.

SETTING GAMES IN THE TLALOCAN MOONS - DESIGNER'S NOTES

This theatre remains an entirely Black-Ops operation for the UCM, so the ideas presented in Reconquest: Phase 1 are still very relevant at this point in the narrative. The introduction of two more MF-B teams to the fray adds to the possibilities of making a more complex campaign with more players. It's also clear that the PHR have been involved in many colossal battles against the Scourge here, which makes it a perfect place to set a campaign between those two forces specifically.

SOLAR SYSTEM

OCT 19TH, 2671AD, D-UNSPECIFIED



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

OVERVIEW

INTRODUCTION

As you will have read in the recently declassified (down from Level 5 to level 2) accounts attached to the D+250 report, the situation in the home system is grim. Massive enemy concentrations coupled with heavy industrialisation and reinforcement make the prospect of retaking our origin planet daunting.

However, if Earth is viewed as the ultimate and final reserve of Scourge military power, the picture changes. More recent reports indicate that a considerable portion of Scourge fleet assets have since been diverted to the Olympus theatre, where a great many of them were destroyed in the massive engagement there.

In addition, word from our Resistance allies on the ground indicates that a significant proportion of Scourge ground forces are being lifted from the planet as we speak, presumably to bolster their losses in other theatres. While this means that our armies elsewhere must be ready to deal with waves of Scourge reinforcements, it is hoped that these will be spread thinly between the Cradle Worlds.

ORBITAL OPERATIONS

A large number of low-key reconnaissance ops are currently underway with the continuing mission of building up a detailed picture of the theatre for battle planners. Fleet support for these endeavours is exclusively in the form of Lysander class stealth lighters as these are the only ships we can count on to make it past the enemy undetected.

There has been no sign of the mysterious enemy that destroyed the Azure Night near Callisto and all indications are that it was of non-Scourge origin.

The Admiralty believes that the Lysanders are proof against Scourge ships at least and seem to be evading PHR ships in other theatres acceptably. As such, the unknown foe was most likely Shaltari, although this is unconfirmed.

Policy is to give Callisto a wide-birth while we conduct ops elsewhere for the moment. Naval Theory is working on a plan to reconnoitre this moon without the use of Lysanders and will report back in due course.

ORBITAL OPERATIONS - EUROPA

+++ This section Classified level 6 - High Council, Supreme Admiral and Naval Theory authorised personnel Eyes Only +++

Besides planning and conducting a considerable number of recon missions, Naval Theory is beginning to work on the first plan to actively damage the enemy in the Solar system. The target has been identified as Europa, one of Jupiter's moons. It has been discovered that 'pure' Scourge require water unfettered by biological contaminants for optimal existence. Pure Scourge are all those without living hosts, most notably almost all vehicle crews and machine operators.



The massive frozen H2O reserves which are devoid of all life on Europa are a perfect and almost limitless source which may well be supplying a large portion of the enemy with vital sustenance. Purification of water is of course possible and indeed common but the Scourge have devoted considerable resources to extraction here.

Theory is working on a daring plan to form a temporary but substantial force (designated: Taskforce Europa) to attack and destroy these facilities, then jump away before a coordinated response can be brought to bear by the Scourge.

This will deny a significant portion of one of the most vital resources to the enemy, causing great disruption that may aid a future invasion of Earth. Only fast ships will be employed and speed as well as absolute secrecy will be required. Europa is currently lightly defended (for a system with such a high concentration of Scourge ships) and the element of surprise will be crucial.

A Strike Carrier based ground assault element will also be needed as the two largest facilities are subterranean and largely invulnerable to orbital bombardment. Surface temperatures outside the atmospherically normalised grav-compensated Scourge facilities are a lethal -150 degrees Celsius so all combat units must be fully winterised and deploy in sealed transports. The insertion teams will be furnished with tactical nuclear demolition charges, to be activated once extraction is complete.

Naval Theory is currently in the process of assembling the fleet under the guise of a live fire exercise over Niccolum. They will shortly be provided with encrypted jump coordinates and sealed orders that are only to be opened once the translation to Jupiter's outer marker is complete. This operation already has Presidential approval and is scheduled to commence on Nov. 1st.

SURFACE OPERATIONS - EARTH

All surface ops on Earth itself are still strictly non-combative. The enemy is simply too numerous and well entrenched for offensive operations to make a serious impact at this time. However, we have had some success in coordinating with and linking up Resistance groups and may be able to consider commencing guerrilla warfare activities against the enemy shortly.

In addition, massive amounts of useful intel has already been gathered, with more pouring in on an almost weekly basis. One curious pattern seems to be emerging around the area of New York City. Large groups of Resistance appear to be heading that way, unguided by our influence but clearly with some great purpose. It must be noted that the deserter Lt. Colonel Rodriguez was last seen in the area and it is possible that he is using Colonial equipment to assist in this. We will be directing two MF-R teams to the region shortly to investigate further.

SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

Almost every vaguely habitable body in the solar system has considerable enemy presence. Most planets and moons are deeply inimical to human (or Scourge) life outside compensated structures.

Unfortunately these structures are sealed and very difficult to penetrate covertly. Nevertheless, plans to infiltrate some captured pre-war facilities on Mars and Titan are being drafted as substantial enemy activity has been identified by orbital scans here. AHQ and the Admiralty await these plans for approval.

SETTING GAMES IN THE SOLAR SYSTEM - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The UCM still has a very modest presence in system, but this is set to change soon with the planned operations. In addition to those suggested in Reconquest: Phase 1, here are some more ideas for gaming in this system:

- 1) Guerrilla activity - The growing and inspired Resistance groups that have made contact with UCM recon teams will likely be keen for some action and it's only a matter of time before they start the ground war on Earth themselves. You could stage the very first true battle on the home planet for over 160 years or run a campaign based on a growing insurgency against the Scourge.
- 2) What's happening in New York? - This section of the book is written from the UCM's perspective, who still know very little of Lt. Colonel Rodriguez. This character is now playable and has his own entry as a Famous Commander in this book (rules can be found later in the book, in the Resistance Units section) which details more of his exploits since deserting the UCMA. His attempts to take direct action through rallying the Resistance of New York City would make for an engaging series of games!
- 3) The Europa Raid - The ground assault element of this planned operation would be a good place to stage the very first full scale engagement in our home system. As another underground setting, some of the scenery made for other theatres (such as the Styx Moon) could be re-used here. You could also use a board where the scenery (and environmental rules) changes as troops move into a massive Scourge facility via a frozen, low-grav wasteland.



THE UNITED COLONIES OF MANKIND

STATUS AS OF OCT 19TH,
2671AD (D+500)

Five hundred days have passed since the vast endeavour of the Reconquest was launched with the invasion of Eden Prime. Millions of loyal soldiers and sailors of the Colonies have since perished in the fiery slaughter of the greatest war mankind has ever seen. However, the people of the UCM remain resolute and unbroken, buoyed by news of every victory, stoic and accepting of their losses. As the carnage grinds on, strategists have been forced to change plans and react to a series of setbacks and unexpected turns...

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

It has proven extremely difficult for the UCM to completely eradicate the enemy from planets they have all but conquered. Total victory in both the Eden and Elysium system was supposed to have been achieved by this point, but remaining Scourge ground forces are proving tenacious opposition. With the enemy mostly confined to dense pockets in a few major cities on both planets, the final assaults will likely be bloody in the extreme. With intent to preserve these cities rather than flatten them from orbit, the only recourse is ground assault until every last Scourge has been exterminated.

However, as the campaign progresses the notion that every one of the Cradle World's cities can be preserved is quickly turning into a fantasy. A murderous act at the hands of the feral warlord Salakahn saw the annihilation of Atlantia City in its entirety by several concealed strategic nuclear warheads. Also on Eden Prime, the centre of the city of Star Casablanca is marked for destruction by UCM tactical nuke, which it is hoped will destroy the densest concentration of Scourge armour left on the planet. This decision was not taken lightly and will involve raids against the last of the Scourge missile halo before such a strike will be possible. The city of New Athens represents the final enemy stronghold on the planet and preparation for the assault is underway, albeit harassed and disrupted by Shaltari interdiction attacks.

While the campaign on Elysium Prime has achieved its objective of cutting the enemy off from a major food supply, final victory on the ground is now likely to be many months away. With the main goal achieved, planners are siphoning troops off to other theatres and reducing reinforcements to a trickle. Ground forces there will have to dig deep and fight a bitter war without limitless recourses to wrest control of the planet once and for all.



The third full-scale ground campaign of the Reconquest so far is in progress in the Shangri-La system. Early gains were acceptable and largely on track, but forces there are now beset by the arrival of a massive PHR fleet and accompanying ground forces. The Republic is making planetfall in several obscure regions and clearly has plans of its own. Whatever their purpose, the presence of such a force will undoubtedly slow the UCM offensive as the Legions face the new foe.

THE TIDES OF OLYMPUS

The void war for the Olympus system rages on. The initial fleet action lasted for nine full days and saw the destruction of over a thousand vessels. Since this record-breaking engagement, the battered but triumphant UCM fleet has been hit by wave after wave of Scourge reinforcements, making it difficult to operate in this theatre to this day.

The vast amount of orbiting debris from the graveyard of a thousand ships has also severely disrupted landing ops. While the UCMA must wait at least two months for enough to burn up to make the approach safe for their bulk landers, Strike Carriers have begun landing expeditionary forces. With the element of surprise long since lost, their objective is to destroy anti-orbital installations of all kinds to carefully pave the way for the future invasion.

The battle for Olympus' colossal orbital defence grid is also still ongoing, with landing ops into the heart of these vast, atmo-enveloped structures being the preferred route to victory, since capture of these vast stations is preferable to their destruction.

NEW FRONTS AWAIT

While these four Cradle World systems are the present focus of the UCM's wrath, the remaining three are being prepared and investigated for future invasions. However, mysterious occurrences seem commonplace and are complicating matters considerably. The Asgard system is currently closed off due to Resistance betrayal, the planet Aaru is seeing heavy Shaltari involvement and the Tlalocan Moons are still shrouded in secrecy for most Colonials, as unknown to them, the PHR have almost entirely conquered the system for themselves.



Meanwhile, the ultimate prize of Earth itself remains a distant prospect. With battle raging on multiple fronts and enemy presence in the Solar system still massive, it is currently unassailable. However, hope remains, as large numbers of Scourge ships and increasing quantities of ground forces are departing Earth to reinforce the Cradle Worlds. If the UCM can but triumph in the face of these new arrivals, Earth may be unprotected enough for an invasion to commence.

THE LATEST TECH HITS THE FRONTLINE

The Colonial military-industrial machine is a highly dynamic, constantly evolving entity. Designs can pass from the drawing board to the frontline in a spectacularly short time as the needs of the UCMA change. The latest weapons systems and vehicles are entering service on an almost monthly basis, greatly expanding the options a UCM general has for annihilating the foe with railgun, missile and cannon.

As the conflicts shift from early stage invasions to bloody street fighting, heavy weapons are being issued in greater numbers to the mighty Colonial Legions. Crew served mortars and flak cannons are a welcome addition, giving the infantry close protection against aircraft and light vehicles when employed en-mass. Also, the innovative adaption of Heavy Hazard suits to a battlefield role has given the infantry powerful walking anti-tank capability, while providing unrivalled protection against harsh environments and enemy fire.

After a trial period in the hands of General Arthur J. Wade, the formidable Broadsword Super-Heavy Tank is being introduced to the Colonial Armoured Corps on a large scale. This mighty behemoth packs an enormous railgun, specifically designed to do devastating damage to larger surface threats such as the gigantic PHR Type-4 walkers and the lethal Scourge Oppressors.

In the skies, the mighty Phoenix Command Gunship reigns supreme as a powerful weapons platform, while the flexible new B-variant of the stalwart Falcon Gunship adds tactical options. Not to be outdone, the UCMF's Fleet Air Arm has also introduced the Seraphim Retaliator, a focused anti-tank variant of the lethal ground attack aircraft capable of destroying multiple vehicles in a deadly salvo of missiles.

THE SCOURGE

**STATUS AS OF OCT 19TH,
2671AD (D+500)**

Although the UCM has thrown almost everything it has against the Scourge for 500 days, the vile aliens are still far from being a spent force. Their setbacks so far in the war can be considered inevitable due to the sheer scale of the invasions ranged against them. However, now that the initial attacks have run their course, the Scourge will be looking to respond with customary aggression and merciless rage.

FIGHT TO THE LAST

Scourge forces on Eden Prime and Elysium are on the brink of final defeat, but several armies are intact and ready to resist the UCM in well prepared ground. Since their void control is lost to the Colonials, these Scourge ground forces will need to fight ferociously and hold out with little hope of reinforcement for the present. This situation is mirrored on the Tlalocan Moons, where the invading PHR forces are facing a similar task of stamping out the remaining Scourge in conquered territory.

While there is evidence that Scourge lifeforms seem to value their own lives, it must be said that they are far more willing to die for the greater good of their species and inflicting damage to the enemy (if circumstances call for it) than humans are. Scourge warriors faced with certain death have never, ever, been seen to desert or surrender. They will always fight to the last, selling their lives dearly and exacting a great toll on their foes. Such behavioural patterns make assailing the Scourge when their backs are against the wall a deadly thing to contemplate, especially in situations where lesser armies would surrender en-mass. The use of tactical nukes against Scourge redoubts is even being explored by the UCM, so unpalatable is the prospect of assaulting them.

THE BEAST STIRS

Thus far in the campaign, the Scourge have been unexpectedly slow to respond to the Reconquest. While reinforcements have been moving with increasing frequency, they are yet to attempt what would be termed as a true counter-offensive. Given the famous aggression and merciless cruelty of the Scourge, this has surprised planners.

It has been postulated that what passes for command in the Scourge hierarchy is perhaps waiting for the Reconquest to falter before responding, spending lives in order to weaken the 'invaders'. When a counter-attack does occur it will then be facing a weary foe that can be more easily broken by an iron fist. Where this hammer blow will fall is uncertain, but it seems increasingly likely that Scourge forces are gathering strength for pro-active operations, largely by siphoning some of Earth's mighty garrison force. In any case, the UCM should be braced for counterattacks on any front, in all probability a truly horrific attack that will shake the Reconquest to its core.

FRESH HOSTS

Meanwhile, the search for new hosts to dominate continues. Seed ships are still being launched, and in the face of combat losses Scourge efforts to vat-grow fresh human hosts have intensified. It seems that with the pressure caused by the Reconquest there is a new urgency among the aliens to replenish their losses. Breeding hives are being constructed in unassailed Scourge territory at an alarming rate and it has been postulated that the enemy may have found a way to vastly accelerate the growth process.

While the failure rate and resource requirement still seems very high in most facilities, the acceleration of host growth from years to mere months (if the reports are to be believed) is cause for the deepest concern. If the Scourge are able to solve the failure rate issue then the UCM could be faced with an unstoppable tide of new foes. However, the parasite itself must reach intellectual maturity before it can be fully combat effective, a process known to take over a year. This fact may provide the UCM with a small but vital time buffer if such a breakthrough were to be achieved by the loathsome aliens.

NEW NIGHTMARES TO FACE

The Scourge are a highly diverse, adaptable foe which also utilize a wide range of non-human hosts for specific tasks. More and more of these usually terrifying bioforms have



been encountered by the UCM as it conquers more territory. It also seems that the Scourge reserve certain specialist hosts as the last line of defence or only employ them in times of dire need. Those that are impossible to vat-grow and have slow natural growth cycles, such as the gargantuan Screamer, are a typical example. These vicious beings are a force to be reckoned with on the battlefield, but are precious assets only brought to bear when destroying the foe both physically and mentally is required. Being able to rip a tank in half is certainly a contributing factor to the Screamer's lethality! As a result, the Screamer is so large that it requires its own class of dropship, the Raider; a craft that also poses a lethal threat to infantry cowering in structures in fear of the Screamer's onslaught.

The first airborne host bioform witnessed by the UCM has also recently been committed en-mass to the frontline. The Vampires are winged abominations, hitching rides on the outer surfaces of Scourge dropships, leaping into air when their prey is near. They are a particularly potent threat to dropships and slow aircraft, where they can latch on and inject plasma into the airframe, causing catastrophic damage.

As the situation grows desperate for cornered Scourge formations, the aliens are also unleashing some of their most crazed and potent close assault troops. The aptly named Eviscerators are aged parasites infesting a Destroyer host. Much like with the Aged Ones using human hosts, these monstrosities increase exponentially in aggression and loss of pain response at the expense of fine motor control and sanity. Their inability to aim projectile weapons is more than made up for by their ability to rend whole squads of Legionaires to shreds in moments. They should only be approached with extreme caution, preferably from behind a wall of tanks!



As the frontlines approach the core of Scourge territory, more leadership constructs are being sighted beyond the solely aggressive Desolator types. The Overseer uses the same basic structural design but it prefers to avoid engaging the enemy itself and instead uses its advanced power projection technologies to greatly boost the effectiveness of nearby plasma weapons. This is particularly potent where the Scourge are densely packed, an occurrence growing all the more frequent in this war. Another command vehicle, the Oppressor, is a walker with thick armour and potent anti-tank weapons. This massive construct is extremely tough and far more effective at holding ground than lighter Scourge vehicles, increasing its utility in defensive actions. UCM vehicle crews are under orders to target and destroy these constructs as a top priority, since the presence of a single one of them can greatly unbalance an engagement in favour of the Scourge.



THE POST-HUMAN REPUBLIC

STATUS AS OF OCT 19TH,
2671AD (D+500)

Up until recently, the Post Human Republic appeared to be a highly active but small-scale player in the wars of the Reconquest. It was thought that they simply did not have the numbers necessary for large scale engagements. However, top secret reconnaissance reports from the Tlalocan Moons revealed that the PHR in fact possess the capacity to launch full sized, system wide invasions if they so wish. Five hundred days into the Reconquest, it seems that Republic control of that system is now almost total. In addition, the PHR are stepping up their involvement in other theatres, leading many to believe that the most crucial intelligence gap for the UCM is knowledge of their mysterious mission...

OPERATIONS INTENSIFY

PHR landing operations in multiple war torn theatres are now underway, most notably in the Shangri-La system. A massive PHR fleet has made its presence felt by temporarily taking control of the system's void from the UCM. A series of purposeful Strike Carrier spearhead landings spread throughout Shangri-La Prime indicate a powerful motivation. The UCM are treating this major incursion as an excellent opportunity to find out more about the Republic's mission.

On Asgard, the PHR instigated the betrayal of the newly arrived UCM expeditionary force, shutting down the nodes and making the whole system inaccessible to the Colonies. A similar pattern of intense, localised operations appeared to be unfolding there before loss of contact with the force, indicating that the PHR plan was not simply confined to one system.

On a smaller scale, the PHR continue to interfere with UCM operations throughout the Reconquest, striking with seemingly random and apparently unconnected actions. It must be assumed that they intend to steer the war in the direction they'd prefer. It is hoped that this direction can be ascertained before it's too late, should that intention prove aggressive towards the UCM.

Meanwhile, something altogether more momentous has been occurring on the Tlalocan Moons...

THE INVASION OF TLALOCAN

Black-Ops recon reports from the Tlalocan Moons have reported on a massive, full scale invasion by the PHR there. Hundreds of ships and multitudes of landing craft have been observed and it seems that the Scourge forces there are close to collapse.

In addition, it has been documented that the Republic is fortifying and building permanent structures and substantial orbitals on its new acquisition, implying that something very different is occurring there. All other PHR landings have been temporary strike and fade style ops,

where when objectives are achieved, the forces melt away back to orbit. It seems obvious that the PHR intend to add the Tlalocan Moons to whatever group of planets they may already hold. The latter point is still an open question for UCM intelligence analysts as they are no closer to learning anything about the PHR homeworld(s).

The UCM has decided for the moment not to initiate a full scale war against the PHR in the system as they are too hard pressed elsewhere to open a new front against a poorly understood enemy. Nevertheless, recon operations in the theatre are bound to be stepped up, as this represents a unique opportunity to finally unravel at least some truth about the PHR's wider plans and machinations in this war.

EYES WITHIN

It is becoming increasingly obvious to both AHQ and the Admiralty that high ranks within the Colonial military, not to mention civil leadership, are riddled with PHR spies. All too often, Republic forces are already present at UCM beachheads, intervene at critical moments or disappear just before a strike is planned against them. Such foreknowledge can only come from espionage, something the PHR are most likely the undisputed masters of.

As bleak as this situation may appear, some analysts are choosing to believe that it indicates the PHR have no desire to destroy the UCM or conquer the Colonies. Given the well known leaks and foreknowledge of operations it should be a relatively easy task for the PHR to cause total chaos and devastation from within, something they don't seem to be attempting. Others merely insist that it is further proof of some grand plan, claiming that these are just the opening salvos of an elaborate scheme to destabilise the UCM slowly and methodically rather than resorting to the obvious. Time (and hopefully more successful counter-espionage) may reveal more...



NEW MARVELS OF WAR

PHR weapons of war represent the very pinnacles of human science and as such are far more dangerous than any UCM equivalent. As more PHR forces enter the fray, an increasing number of outlandish and spectacular technologies are being revealed, further highlighting the distance between the post-humans and the Colonials.

First and foremost among these are units which utilise highly advanced nanomachines or drone swarm technologies. Units such as the Aether Jetskimmer can unleash swarms to deadly nanomachines, tearing into the internal systems of vehicles and flesh alike from a concealed position. Similar technology can be seen on the Triton-X Strike Dropship. This craft seems to be reserved exclusively for the majestic Medusas. These are devastatingly powerful individuals, able to direct whole swarms of drones and nanomachines with a single mind, each individual being a one woman army capable of sweeping whole groups of tanks aside.

The PHR are also stepping up their use of more mobile units to supplement their near-unstoppable heavy walkers. The highly agile (and previously experimental) Hera Strike Walker provides a command and control element to equally manoeuvrable Apollo, Erebus and Jetskimmer formations. This potent vehicle has been extensively tested and championed by Jocasta Caine, although few can equal her in skill at piloting one. On the infantry front, Valkyrie teams represent a new and unpredictable threat to all troops fighting in urban environments through the use of flight packs, lending each warrior astonishing mobility.

Heavy vehicles and extreme firepower are still the mainstay of PHR armies however (and nowhere is this more obvious than with the Nemesis Command Walker). This towering Type-4 variant is armed with an extremely potent directed energy weapon which is capable of slicing through even the heaviest armoured units. Even basic infantry are appearing with heavier weapons such as the Immortal Longreach Teams; whole squads of armoured soldiers armed with powerful anti-material rifles capable of decimating almost anything on the ground from concealed positions. All UCM

officers operating near PHR patrols are advised to stay in their vehicles with the hatches and vents firmly sealed as a matter of precaution, although even heavy vehicle armour does not provide full protection against their high velocity weapons.

It is clear that as this war progresses, the PHR's involvement is likely to intensify. They certainly have the firepower, a mission and may even have the numbers to be an absolutely pivotal factor in the coming months of carnage.



THE SHALTARI TRIBES

**STATUS AS OF OCT 19TH,
2671AD (D+500)**

As ever, the Shaltari are proving enigmatic, illusive and inscrutable opponents in the wider war. Evidence of their involvement is everywhere but rarely can they ever be brought to battle en-mass. This ancient race is certainly taking an extremely active role in the conflict, though the exact aim or result of their deadly machinations is still unclear. Whatever their purposes and despite their small numbers, the Shaltari Tribes are some of the most dangerous combatants throughout the battlefields of the Reconquest and should never be underestimated. Unfortunately for the UCM, they are even harder to read than they are to defeat.

FACTIONAL WARFARE

One solid fact that is well known about the Shaltari tribes is that they will just as readily fight each other as they will 'lesser' races. It was previously thought that these were only a sort of 'test of strength' against the only opponent worthy of respect, themselves. However, in recent months a pattern has begun to emerge from the chaos.

Conflict between the Tribes is always between certain groups, indicating the existence of distinct alliances. Most notably, a large faction including the Apache, Masai, Aztecs, Comanche, Amazons, Zulus and Inuit are in conflict with a smaller collective including the Mongols, Cherokee, Icini and Tlaxcallan. Although the UCM are a long way from determining any sort of motive for the struggle, such cross-tribe cooperation and group conflict suggests differing ideals on a more significant level than simple tests of strength. That these internecine confrontations are happening across the Cradle Worlds indicates that this is a central issue for the Shaltari and that it pertains in some way to these planets and/or to the Reconquest and its progress.

WAR PUPPETEERS

Another obvious fact (frequently learned the hard way) is that the Shaltari are deliberately and shrewdly manipulating the other factions in this war. Their random attacks on certain convoys, infrastructure and armoured columns make no apparent sense when looked at any other way.

These raids are focused just as often on the Scourge or the PHR as they are on the UCM and the Resistance. What these interventions all have in common is that they have had a wider effect on the outcome of crucial engagements, although just as often to the UCM's advantage as its disadvantage.

It is impossible to find a more meaningful pattern at this stage though, as Shaltari from all faction groups are participating in such activities with equally unclear end goals.

Without a breakthrough in intelligence the UCMA has focused on dealing with these alien incursions as they arise, and is expecting more of them in the future. Meanwhile, hordes of analysts in both Army and Naval intelligence are pouring over mountains of data to attempt to discern a pattern from the chaos.

THE BATTLE FOR AARU

The only theatre in which the Shaltari have committed serious numbers so far is on the Cradle World of Aaru. It has been postulated that this planet may have some ancient significance to the Shaltari, a theory perhaps vindicated by the comparatively large amount of resources they are committing to battle there. It is thought that with the Scourge occupiers weakened by a UCM sponsored Resistance guerrilla campaign and by the loss of troops to other





theatres, the Shaltari are seizing the chance to try and conquer the planet. They have already established a defensible beachhead in the Southern hemisphere and are beginning to encroach northward.

UCM advance teams on the ground however feel that the possibility of them taking the planet is remote as Shaltari numbers are simply too few to overcome the Scourge at current deployment levels. Having said that, enemies of the Shaltari should always remember that they never do anything without good reason, and they are frequently many moves ahead in this galactic-scale game of chess.

CONSTRUCTS OF CATACLYSM

As always with the Shaltari, every new war machine categorised is as breathtakingly advanced as it is lethal. While none of these freshly discovered constructs are likely to be 'new' designs in terms of when they were conceived, they have only recently been observed in numbers on the frontline.

New and deadly types of the Shaltari's signature heavy tripod walkers are now making their presence felt. The Panther represents a uniquely problematic threat as a powerful directed energy anti-air platform, giving it range against countermeasures far in excess of anything using solid ammunition. This reaper of aircraft can operate far from the frontline, picking off dropships and gunships with ease and impunity. The Leopard, in contrast, is a close range tank-killer of insatiable lethality, favoured only by the most aggressive and battle-hungry of the Shaltari elite. Whole columns of heavy armour have been reduced to molten slag in the wake of their unstoppable advance.

Larger variants of the Shaltari's standard infantry battlesuits are also appearing. Designated by the UCM as Ronin and Samurai, these towering suits are large enough to be considered vehicles. Packing an array of deadly weaponry too potent for a normal battlesuit to carry, these terrors can respond with lethal speed while eliminating vehicles and infantry with Gauss Carbine, Bio-Atomiser and Energy Glaive.

Another recent development is the increasing deployment of auxiliary fighters of non-Shaltari origin. The first of these are the diminutive but numerous Pungari. This stunted race exists in a state of virtual (if apparently voluntary) servitude to their Shaltari masters and they fight with reckless abandon, selling their lives gladly.

This puts them in stark contrast to their masters and gives the Shaltari access to something they usually lack - numbers. However underwhelming a single Pungari is in combat, the problem is that there are always many more of them to deal with!

In the skies, a more aggressive, assault-oriented variant of the Thunderbird Gunship has appeared, designated 'Firebird'. This hunter-killer employs very close range but highly energised weaponry designed specifically to destroy bulky targets. Crews of command units, large vehicles and heavy tanks should be especially wary of these new airborne terrors.



THE RESISTANCE

**STATUS AS OF OCT 19TH,
2671AD (D+500)**

It is virtually impossible to sum up the disposition of the Resistance in the war so far as they are so disparate, varied and singular in culture, aims and equipment. No two Resistance groups are exactly alike and each has their own unique set of circumstances and problems to deal with. In general though, almost all Resistance hate the Scourge with a passion above and beyond even the UCM, and most have been natural allies to the Colonials in the Reconquest.

Their deep local knowledge and on the ground intel gathering capabilities continue to be invaluable, as does their capacity to strike behind enemy lines to disproportionate effect. However, far from all Resistance groups are a force for good, a fact hammered home by recent events on Eden Prime...

THE ANNIHILATION OF ATLANTIA

The despotic warlord known as Salakahn has been a thorn in the UCM's side since the early days of the Reconquest on Eden Prime. This scheming megalomaniac has been desperately trying to maintain his iron grip over his domains at the expense of progress and had even forged an alliance with the PHR in exchange for equipment. The Republic clearly had their own purpose in aligning with such a monster and it seemed that their operations in his home city of Atlantia were reaching their final stages when UCM troops entered the city.



As one of the last major Scourge strongholds on the planet, the UCM had committed nearly a full Legion and two full Armoured Corps to the assault. Boxed in and with the prospects of losing his domains at last, it seems that Salakahn decided to resort to the darkest of moves against his own race rather than capitulate. Beneath the streets of the city, Salakahn had been storing multiple strategic nuclear warheads. When the UCM spearhead was entering the city centre and most of the Tyrant's troops had quietly fled, Salakahn chose to detonate them all, levelling the entire city and taking almost a million Colonial lives in the process.

This tragic event will be a lesson to all those who would parley with such ruthless individuals in the lengths that such a soul will go to in war, so extreme has been the harshness of their whole existence. It illustrates that although small and poorly equipped, the Resistance are always a factor and a force to be reckoned with through sheer determination and resourcefulness, be that on the side of good or evil.

ALLIANCES MADE, ALLIANCES BROKEN

The Resistance are an obvious ally for any invading force to try to recruit. Since they are rarely numerous or powerful enough to be the true occupiers of territory (and thus the target of an invasion) they are invariably a secondary factor. Due to their lack of resources and deep rooted hatred of the Scourge, such alliances are easily struck with any apparently benevolent force that opens dialogue with them. The UCM and PHR frequently do just that, but even the Shaltari have been seen bartering pacts with the Resistance as it seems even they value the Resistance's unmatched on the ground knowledge.

Such alliances with the Shaltari are almost always temporary while this unscrupulous race conducts its mysterious operations, although pacts with the PHR can be more lasting. The Republic are well known as masters of complex diplomacy, and it seems that they have succeeded in turning Resistance groups against the UCM in some cases. Nowhere was this more obvious than on Asgard, where the Resistance set up an elaborate betrayal against the UCM expeditionary force, cutting the Colonies off from the entire system in the process.

ASYMMETRIC WARFARE

In the service of any ally or when fighting entirely for their own purposes, the Resistance remain the masters of asymmetric guerrilla warfare. This has been harnessed to great effect by the UCM on Eden Prime, Aaru and Elysium Prime in particular, where their assistance has been invaluable. The UCM is likely to step up such initiatives in future in view of their success as such allies become tightly woven into the military strategies of the Colonies.



The use of more ambitious home-brewed weapons is also increasing as such creations are pressed into battle as the war grows more intense. Thunder Wagons (a generic term) are truck-based weapons platforms mounting an enormous, crude but lethal missile, packing enough explosives to destroy multiple tanks in one shot. These are seen more rarely than the common Storm Wagons and are most effective when deployed in smaller numbers.

On the subject of blowing things up, Resistance demolition experts (often unhinged individuals known as Sappers) are an interesting factor, preparing the ground ahead of battles with a devilish collection of explosive devices, detonating them with glee when the time is right.

The use and modification of antique, pre-war military equipment also continues and less common vehicles are now being committed to the fray. The Mehmed Siege Tank is a superlative building destroyer although the potency of its massive calibre, short ranged shells against heavy armour should not be underestimated. Enemy tanks should also fear the Typhoon, a less common variant of the Cyclone Attack Helicopter that is designed solely for anti-tank strikes. Lastly, repurposing of Lifthawk Dropships is becoming an increasingly common factor with such modifications as infantry carrying pods and extra weaponry being added to suit whatever purpose the ingenious mechanics of the Resistance desire.

RECRUITMENT AND RECONSTRUCTION

As full scale fighting draws to a close on Eden Prime, the vast majority of the former Resistance there have been liberated from Scourge oppression and will soon be declared citizens on the UCM. While some groups (such as Salakahn's followers) will no doubt oppose this, the majority are welcoming it with jubilant relief. However, the UCM needs every pair of hands it can get and it is a fair assumption that their war is far from over. A crucial component in the Reconquest plan is that each conquered planet begins to contribute to the war effort, unbalancing the scales in the UCM's favour.

Eden Prime will be the first test of this scheme with Colonial bodies already in place to govern reconstruction, industrial output and recruitment. Raising of Eden's 1st Colonial Legion is now underway and it seems likely that this ex-Resistance body will be an elite, hardened force from the moment of its inception. Unlike all other Legions, almost every soldier will have had the experience of a lifetime of war and hardship. If they can be trained and honed into a true military outfit coupled with the latest tech, then the arrival of such a force on the frontline will be a true game-changing shift in the war of the Reconquest.

CUNNING CONTRAPTIONS

New and intriguing Resistance fighting forces are being encountered on a regular basis due to their vast diversity. These new units fall into two basic categories; improvised and ex-military. With improvised units, the repurposing of civilian vehicles to military roles is commonplace. The use of small quadbikes and trikes is on the rise since they can carry heavier weapons and more powerful surveillance and electronic warfare gear than smaller two-wheeled bikes.

